

The spirit of Ashen is to burn bright and burn fast. Whether it was due to the heat of the caldera the it was built around or the ashes of the city it was built upon, it's people knew fiery passions, steadfast faith, and lost sleep.

Seldom do the people embody these principles as much as the Professor. Exhaustion clung to him like ash, followed him wherever he went. Yet his body took him from school to school, lab to lab, his work being rewarded with more work.

Once upon a time, he had peers, even friends. Right until they burned into a hollow husk of themselves or the weight crushed them into irrelevancy. Even now, as he dozed off in a small, candlelit office, his closed eyes imagined himself going through the giant stack of papers. The glyph is wrong in this spot. The proposed binding is ineffective in that context. This paper doesn't have a name to grade.

Eyes in deep, heavy sockets opened to his desk. The lone candle at the side was almost through it's life, flickering in dusty air. The Professor rolled his chair closer, grabbing one of the many quills strewn about. His hand dashed across the candle with abandon. The inevitable knock came at his door.

"Professor! Do you have some time? We've got a small situation." A shudder rocked it's way through his office. "Slightly larger situation."

The Professor slipped out of his chair and out the door, not waiting to see the fate of the wobbling candle. He smoothed

his raggedy lab coat as he passed by the fresh faced student at his door. Their robes were still bright and fresh, with eyes still wide-eyed to match. A *newer wick, then.*

"Hurry, hurry," The Professor beckoned the student to his side as he broke into a brisk walk. Other students and faculty of their university wandered through the halls on the way to their next task. Many of them greeted the Professor with a curt nod, others clamored for his attention before being waved off. Another shudder racked it's way through the halls and dust fell from ceiling, everyone pausing for a moment before going about their day. "Where's this situation of yours?"

The young wick hurried forward and in moments they lead the Professor through a labyrinth of hallways and stairs. Whenever the two passed a window, the Professor spotted large blocks of stone swirling around their building.

"You see, we thought we could enchant a scale model of the Chandlery," The wick explained as they climbed higher. "A way to construct or demolish rooms as needed. It worked! Maybe a little too well."

A stray room dashed close against their window. There were a couple of other students inside anchoring themselves whichever way they knew best.

Soon after, they made it to the Observatory at the top. The observatory itself wasn't very large. It was named such due to the glass dome that offered access to the stars. But truth be told, it was a cramped room that could fit a

handful of people on a good day, even less when some enterprising students thought their project needed a birds eye view. It was no different today.

From within the room, a chandelier was laying on it's side. There were multiple layers of rings that connected candle to candle, with several arms connecting each ring to the main body. Magic pulsed from within it as debris and other parts of it orbited around. The aptly named Chandlery, a scale model of the building they were in. Right below it, a magic circle pulsed with each shudder that went through the halls.

On the opposite side of the room, a floating student, hood up and legs crossed. Their robes were significantly more worn and tattered. The natural colors have long since faded, yet the patches shined and pulsed with the same magic that connected to the model in front of them.

"Litwick Yewl, I've brought the Professor."

The student shook the hood off their head, long teal hair spilling out. Magic lines were scrawled on wooden skin, the Professor recognized the form as *Trance*, where the magic without is channeled as magic within. Their eyes glowed gold; the Professor did not know what they saw through their eyes, only that the magic was coursing through them.

"Come now, Yewl," the Professor crossed his arms. On soundless steps, he studied the model in front of him. "I think this is far beyond my help."

"Moral support is always helpful,

Professor," Yewl's hands warped the model in front of them. Their hands kept the model together, even as each erstwhile shake shook them, then the model. "I've already thought about stilling the room for a brief stopgap, but the feedback has already gotten too far."

The Professor took another moment to study the model, then beckoned for the young wick. "Do not tell me you are so short-sighted that you did not think of a countermeasure."

The wick opened their mouth, then thought better of it.

"I only hope this will be a learning for you which your professors have neglected to impart," the Professor cleared his throat and then rolled his soldiers. "Very well, tell me how you've made this."

The youngest wick then went over the model and explained the workings of it to the Professor. Much of which he already surmised, but the exact details and matching of the glyphs were still helpful.

"Why haven't you undone the key-runes individually?" The Professor asked.

"If we did, the link would weaken, causing the demand of aether to increase."

"And with Litwick Yewl already forced to keep the model together, the demand might overwhelm them," the Professor already knew how this tale ended. It was not an uncommon occurrence with new wicks. Nor was it uncommon for his pupil to step in when they really shouldn't.

"It'll be tough," Yewl said.

"Unfortunately, it's also the only

viable option" the Professor stroked his chin. "What's your capacity? I'd wager you're at half."

"A little over," Yewl closed their eyes in focus. "If I deepen my trance, I can double capacity. Maybe triple if we're lucky."

"Hope we're lucky," the Professor snapped his fingers in attention. "Alright, bring me a knife. Show me the key-runes."

"Of course Professor, right away Professor," the wick pointed out the runes which held the most aether and most pathways to other concentrations.

"As you are well aware, each key-rune bears the brunt of a spell. If we break one," the Professor stabbed into a rune as demonstration. In response, another shudder wracking through. "The spell becomes less efficient, requiring more aether to maintain the spell." He glanced to Yewl. "How is it?"

Yewl nodded in response.

"Excellent, we'll continue," the Professor grabbed the floating room out of the air and held it down to the ground. Outside, he heard the flying room come to a stop. There were other bits still orbiting, but that was the largest and most dangerous. "Hold this."

"Professor, can we not use a spell to still the Chandlery? Litwick Yewl said they were not able to but maybe you can." The wick asked as the two marked the key-runes for the Professor to dismantle. "The story say—"

"Then you must hear more stories about

me, for the spell is beyond me," the Professor kept tabs on Yewl. Complete focus and stillness marked their face. Their hands kept moving, shaping the spell through ever-increasing demands. "What about you? Have you tried it yet?"

"No, Professor," the wick said.

"Why not?"

"The spell is beyond me, I cannot even begin to fathom it."

"Then you have already failed and we must continue with plan A."

The young wick asked no more questions. Though their start was smooth, locating and disabling relevant runes began to slow their pace as the obvious candidates were taken care of. For many moments, the room was the *tink, tink* of the knife, the pulse of magic, and the labored breathing of Yewl, which with each breath became heavier and heavier.

Soon after, the Professor lead both the search and disabling of runes. The young wick could no longer keep up with his pace, nor could the Professor ask that of the wick.

"Professor," Yewl's voice strained, light pouring from her mouth - an the first sign of an overdose.

"Almost there," the Professor continued with unbreakable focus. "Count to three, Yewl."

"One," Yewl's skin began to crack.

"On three, release both the spell and your trance," The Professor's hands were a blur over the model.

"Two," The intermittent shudders turned

to full on shakes. The building couldn't take much more.

"There you are," the Professor stabbed the last key-rune.

The last number left unspoken, Yewl's light stopped as the shakes did. They collapsed and slumped over, the Professor quick to support them from hitting the ground. New magic lines were scrawled where the skin cracked in trance.

"Accompany Litwick Yewl to the nurses please," the Professor called to the young wick. "Tell them I recommend a week of rest and be sure they know I sent you."

"Of course Professor, right away Professor," the young wick support Yewl to their feet and walked with the Professor out the door.

Right outside, long robed officials with clean metal staffs marched barred their path.

"A pack of Delles," the Professor nodded at them. "It's about time. Investigating a disturbance, are you?"

"Professor," the leader of the group and the only one with a wooden staff stepped forward. "How did I know it would be you at the center of this mess?"

The Professor shrugged and motioned for the young wick to go on ahead. The wick bowed before assisting Yewl to the nurses.

"And I assume that he is the culprit?"

"Of course not, that would be me," the Professor began walking, pushing past the group as they followed him.

"Quit the farce," the head Delles tried to stop the Professor, but the Professor just brushed him off. "That's the fifth

incident this week."

"And if you're lucky, it'll stay at five in time for the new week," the Professor continued at a brisk, focused pace. "If you want an incident report, I'll add it to my list."

The Professor heard the footsteps behind him stop; he didn't have to look to feel their frustration roll off them.

"You can't keep this up."

The Professor paused at the entrance to a lecture hall. He scanned the seats and found one student much smaller than the others. "And when that day comes, I expect a retirement party."

With the Delles off his back for the time being, the Professor watched the lecture. It was the start of this semester for many of these students. Too new for robes, too new to be even called wicks.

He focused on the small student; a young boy. Black hair, ice blue eyes, and a full head smaller than everyone around him. The boy wrote notes in a notebook he received from the Professor, his expression neutral. Most students were admitted to the Chandlery at fifteen turnings - any younger were to be denied. The boy was admitted at ten turnings - an act done at the Professor's insistence. No other considerations were to be made.

The Professor, satisfied with what he saw, continued on his way. For now, at least, the boy was not struggling. Not visibly, as far as the Professor could tell.

He moved with purpose back to his office. He closed the door behind him and found that the candle had fallen over. To both his elation and annoyance, it fell unto the floor and not on the table itself, leaving his papers unmarred. Couldn't say the same for the floor, but that's a task for later.

The Professor sat behind his desk and stretched his arms into the air. There was an ache in his lower back that came and went. With the ache remaining, he went to work on his stack. Starting from the top, he went and marked them as needed. He came across a wick's report, had to sign off on some administrative work for the Chandlery, approve research...

"I should have these sorted," the Professor sighed. In another time, they were. When night fell and the stack was halved, the Professor yawned and stretched. He rubbed his eyes, getting up and smoothing his ragged robes as he left his office and locked up for the night.

It was dark in the Chandlery now, yet it was active as it was before. The wicks who could simply conjured soft candlelight to guide their paths through their work. Those who could not simply carried candles.

The Professor was among those who could not. He was around long enough to travel the place blindfolded anyway.

As he left the Chandlery, the foundations shook similar to earlier. There was an escort waiting for him by the gate.

"Hello Master Professor," the young man about twenty turnings greeted him. He had short, platinum hair and platinum eyes, with a gray, ashy robe.

"Hello Seer," the Professor greeted him and kept walking. The Chandlery shook behind him.

"Is that something you should take care of?"

"They can handle it."

The Seer hurried to the Professor's side, almost tripping over his own robes in doing so.

"You're late for the decision," the Seer said.

"The decision is already made. Me being there won't change anything."

"But--"

"No 'buts,' Seer," the Professor stopped and abruptly turned to the young man, the Seer almost crashing into him at the suddenness. "If you have an issue with the decision, then it would be best if you spoke up."

The Seer hemmed and hawed over the sleeves of his robe.

"You have spoken up, haven't you?" The Professor sighed.

"I have, Professor," the Seer nodded. "But my concerns are tabled, to be revisited at a later date."

"And no matter how much of a fuss you make, you're shot down," the Professor surmised.

"That's correct, Professor."

"Crotchety. Old. Useless," the Professor muttered underneath his breath and turned to walk again. "Very well. Lead the way, Seer. Let's see what mischief I can get up to for you."

At the Professor's assent, the Seer opened a gate.

"This will take us just outside the control center," the Seer said.

"Open it inside."

"Professor?"

"Inside, Seer," the Professor urged.

"But, the protocol for magic--"

"We're already going around the protocol," the Professor said. "And I do want to upset them."

The Seer paused, the conflict on his face. Then, something in him relented and the Seer waved his hand. The portal flickered. Once it stabilized, the

Professor walked through.

On the other side, the Professor silenced a discussion with his presence.

His eyes adjusted to the magelights around the room. Ahead of him were a congregation of lab coats and robes. There were some armored guards who had their weapons up, but when they saw it was him, they lowered their weapons. Despite himself not having magic, they picked up on the Professor's habit of making surprise entrances.

The Seer followed in right behind him and closed the portal.

All eyes were on the two of them. The Professor did a spin to survey the room - behind them, where most of the others were facing, was a projection of their plans.

The Professor knew, what the plans were, of course. He designed some of them himself. He knew that this particular project was for containing a source of magic. Self-sustaining, incredible output, and not requiring necromantic life energy from half the continent.

For their contemporaries, even within Ashen itself, the project would be considered a fever dream. An irrefutable law is that energy cannot be created or destroyed - to those not in the know, this would violate that law. It would look like generating a sun with the power of a rock.

It was also dangerous and prone to sudden explosions.

The Professor regarded the stares.

"Professor, it was our understanding that you have retired from this project," One of the researchers spoke out, a gray,

ashy woman who was twice the age of the Professor. "Was the Chandlery too restricting for you?"

"Marka," the Professor greeted with a forced smile. "I dare say it's even too freeing. Many of it's alumni does come here, after all."

A murmur went through the crowd. Near the back, off to the side, the Professor saw two of the younger ones exchange some stral. A side bet for a scene often played out.

"Spare me the barbs and the japes, Professor," Marka sighed. "You are here for a reason, are you not? The decision has already been made regarding the design. You can study it top to bottom if you wish, but you will find that it's quite bulletproof."

"Oh no, I don't have an issue with the design," the Professor said. "How could I, when I've had just a moment's glance at it?"

"Then why are you here?"

"Because my replacement has an issue with the design," the Professor stepped back and gestured for the Seer to step forward.

"Yes, these concerns are mine," The Seer stammered, but stepped up, clearing his throat.

"Master Seer," Marka rolled her eyes. "We have already tabled this discussion for a future design. This decision must stand."

"Well for the purposes of the less knowledgeable such as I, might I hear these concerns," the Professor walked

around the room. He could guess, but this was part of the theater.

Marka glared at the Professor, but waved for the Seer to explain.

"Of course," the Seer nodded. He pointed to the design behind them and began to pick apart certain details. The Professor followed with rapt attention, aware of these flaws in the design.

But, the more the Seer connected all these tiny flaws, the more the Professor realized that the design was flawed from the jump.

"In summary, we cannot allow this to move forward in this state. The designs will not be able to support the material," the Seer said.

"There's a lot of pressure from above to make this work," Marka spat out a practiced reply. "Even if this fails, we can refine the design with additional data."

"If we are using this material, we cannot afford a second chance," the Seer said, iron in his voice.

The Professor leaned forward. Of course. It was because the Seer was young that this was a problem. The Seer glanced at the Professor, who smiled and nodded.

"If your concern is the amount of material we have, I assure you we can get more--"

"This material is human lives," the Seer shouted. The room went silent.

The Professor took that as his queue.

"Human lives," the Professor said. "The great big secret of our project. The material we use to build our grand energy

source."

"We've already gone over this," Marka said. She sounded more tired than irate. "Privately, publicly, over months and years."

"Then we can spend another couple days," the Professor stood next to the Seer. "What is your primary concern, Seer?"

"My primary concern is that it is wasteful and in direct challenge of our mission to use the material we currently have for a design that is inherently flawed," the Seer said.

"That sounds reasonable to me," the Professor said. "And what of you?" the Professor pointed at someone in the back. "What is the chief concern?"

"The High Houses," a different person spoke up. "We give them progress, or we're gone."

"The High Houses," the Professor repeated and sighed. It's always them. "Is this true, Marka? Ran out of clout to delay them?"

"No thanks to you," Marka said. "Time is running out. For us, for the High Houses, for Ashen."

"Redesign it," the Professor said. "When a representative of the High Houses come for you, send for me. In the meantime-" the Professor pushed the Seer forward. "As I recall, I deigned the Seer as my replacement. Next time, I implore you to consider the weight of his words."

Another murmur went through the crowd.

"Alright, I said my sermon. Figure out the rest," the Professor nodded to Seer

and waved at Marka. He watched her pinch the bridge of her nose and shook her head.

The Seer got to work, already talking with the congregate.

With no reason to interfere any longer, the Professor slipped out, nodding to the guards as he left.

"Always gotta keep things interesting, don't you?" the guard asked.

"How else are the lights going to stay on?" the Professor chuckled. "It would do for all of them to build a little backbone - can't acquiesce to every demand by the high houses."

"Cheers to that," the guard agreed and said no more.

The research area of Ashen was both bright and suffocating. No windows, white lights, sterile. The only sounds were his own footsteps as people didn't make it a habit to be in the halls. Those that did run into the Professor didn't meet his gaze and fell into their own rooms.

A dizzy spell fell over the Professor and stumbled to a wall. He leaned onto it, taking slow and deep breaths with his eyes closed.

"Should've asked the Seer for a port back," he said when the dizziness faded.

He doubled his stride. Being here any longer would make him sick.

It took awhile to exit the labyrinth of the Research area. When he finally did manage to escape, it was almost day. The first embers of dawn spark to the east. He was on the mountainside, the more dangerous experimental projects buried deep underground of the Caldera which

Ashen was built around.

Instead of moving right away, the Professor took this moment to rest. He breathed deep the morning air, felt the mountain breeze tug at his clothes.

Then, for the first time in a long time, the Professor sat down and let himself relax.

The Professor watched the sun rise over the East of Ashen. For the morning, this was a good place to be. The west would've been cast in the shadow of the caldera.

The sun peaked over the horizon, brightening the Professor's thoughts. He got up and dusted himself off, heading down the mountain. Once he was at the base, he hitched a ride back to the Chandlery.

It was a long day and an even longer night. He had scarcely been back in the research labs for an hour, maybe two, but that was more exhausting than any amount of work in the Chandlery.

He returned to his office to find the door unlocked and slightly ajar. The Professor wasn't worried and already knew what to expect.

A young boy, the very same that he was watching in the class prior. He was asleep on the bench, curled up as a stack of textbooks were on the floor next to him.

The Professor tidied up the books and took his robe off. He readjusted the boy so that his own robes acted as a pillow. Then, the Professor returned to his stack of papers.

The next couple of days were quiet and repetitive. For a blessing, the Professor was able to focus on his faculty work. He actually managed to catch up and was teaching a lecture on the fundamentals of magic before he was so rudely interrupted by reality.

Armed soldiers entered his lecture hall, followed by a messenger dressed in royal purple robes. The first of the high houses, House Richter. They were the strongest of the houses, being most intertwined with the Ashen military.

"Professor [*****]," the Messenger greeted. "We have urgent business with you. Please come with us."

The Professor squinted at the Messenger. The words came out and he heard them. They used his name. They used something that no longer belonged to him. Richter was serious then.

"Alright everyone, continue with your projects. If you run into any questions and I'm not at my office hours, find Litwick Yewl. If you can't find Litwick Yewl, figure it out," the Professor started to walk with the soldiers, then paused. He scanned the crowd and spotted a young boy with blue eyes who was starting to get up. He pointed at him, stopping the boy in his tracks. "Young Kirisame, under no circumstances are you to follow me."

The Professor pushed past the soldiers and walked with the Messenger.

"I see you have found yourself a new protege," the Messenger said. "My employer will find that quite interesting."

"I find that to hardly be news," the

Professor snorted. "I'm faculty. I'm supposed to teach the young wicks. The boy is just another stray."

"Strays," the Messenger savored the word. "Is that how they take it?"

"That's what they are," the Professor ignored the majority of his provocations. He dealt with the Richter's messengers to deal with this much.

The soldiers escorted them outside of the Chandlery. A procession was waiting for them on the road, just outside of Chandlery bounds.

"So the big boss decided to show up personally?" the Professor arched a brow at the Messenger.

"If only for your reputation," the Messenger half-bowed. "I shall take my leave."

"One last thing, before you go," the Professor raised a hand to bid him pause.

The Messenger waited.

"Tell your employer that I'm waiting for him and I don't take his threats idly," the Professor said.

The Messenger's eye twitched, and then he fell back into a portal.

At the center of the procession was a carriage, the door of which, opened for the Professor. He waltzed in, sitting opposite to the man already inside.

Dressed in a fine, purple suit, was a mustached man who was about the Professor's age. He wore a monocle and took off a tall brimmed hat. The man, Solomon Richter, had black skin and green eyes. He grinned, his teeth a pearly white.

"Heartened am I, that you were able to join me on this day, Professor [*****]."

The Professor winced. "Please, just Professor is fine. We've known each other long enough to skip the pleasantries."

"Then Professor, let's cut to the chase," Richter leaned back with this hands folded on his lap. "You've slowed down progress on the Core."

"It's a flawed design," the Professor replied smoothly. Practiced. "It would've been a waste of time and resources. Better to smooth out the kinks before putting it into practice."

"How efficient of you," Richter looked peaked out of the carriage blinders. "But your heart has always been softer than it should have been."

"Softness isn't a flaw," the Professor muttered. If Richter heard him, he didn't show it.

"Our enemies grow stronger day by day," Richter said. "Mount Alchaic wanes by the second. Within the decade we'll lose the natural energy of the leyline and the lack of magic will destroy the city where we sit."

"I'm aware of the stakes."

"Are you?" Richter arced an eyebrow. "Because it will take a year to build this prototype to scale. A year that we don't have. And now you've delayed it further. How long must you live in the theoretical before we must make it practical?"

"We have to do this the right way," the Professor said. "If we don't, then we're scarcely better than the rest of them."

The two of them chewed on each others

words in silence, rocked by the carriage. Richter was right, of course. Unbeknown to the vast majority of Ashen, the city was running on borrowed time. The city was built upon an intersection of leylines, powered by the mountain it was built around. Thanks to the incredible amount of magic pumped through it, the city enjoyed many years of nigh unlimited magic.

The city grew ever further, until the amount of magic they used outweighed the leylines themselves. Consumption is growing, but the resource is dwindling.

But even as Richter was right, the two of them spend many long years fighting mad mage after mad mage. There were many shortcuts to power, all of them dangerous. Even as enemies were outside of their borders, there were many more within their walls.

"I would feel better about the delays if you were to rejoin the project," Richter finally said. "Your knowledge and wisdom would be incredibly valuable."

The Professor shook his head. He flexed his right hand.

"The wisdom is wasted on me," the Professor said. "Even in the old design, the flaws were of my making."

"I wasn't suggesting," Richter said.

"It doesn't matter what you suggest, Solomon," the Professor wrung his right wrist. "At this stage, I will be of a hindrance."

"I disagree."

"I wasn't suggesting," the Professor said in return.

Silence continued for a mote longer.

"Know, the other houses will not be as kind as I am."

"They can take it up with the Archmages," the Professor said. "I answer to them and them alone."

"Them, and your soft heart," Richter reached into his suit and pulled out a folder. "Lest you misunderstand me, I am offering you this information free of charge."

The Professor frowned.

"I know," Richter chuckled. "Of course I have a plan for, or some semblance of one. No such thing as a free lunch and such. But we know each other long enough. Will you refuse this?"

The Professor grimaced. Richter was not like the other houses; he'd plan and scheme, yes. But in matters of true importance, he'd give the Professor enough information to align them to a common goal. With that in mind, the Professor reached for the folder. Richter handed it over without a fuss.

He opened the folder, reading over the contents.

"Across the Fissures, we're finding bodies," Richter explained as the Professor read the details.

"Bodies turn up all the time at the Fissures," the Professor refuted, but he was starting to get the picture. The Fissures were the southern part of Ashen, where the ground cracked and revealed a mighty crevice. On good days, the blood of Mount Alchaic would flow through.

"Normally, yes. But these have been drained of their magic," Richter said.

"You know what this means."

The Professor closed the folder and took a deep breath. Then, he ripped up the folder and contents inside, then let the pieces fall from his fingers. The remains scattered amidst the inside of the carriage, making a mess. Richter eyed them ruefully.

"You really should keep better track of your proteges," He said. The carriage stopped.

"If it comes to it, it comes to it," the Professor went for the door.

Richter grabbed the Professor arm. Not hard, but firm.

"For the safety of Ashen, I would recommend sooner rather than later," Richter gripped harder for a moment. The scattered pieces of Richter's information were set alight, not even turning to ash. Then he let go.

The Professor grunted and left the carriage.

They dropped the Professor off at the Fissures. Mount Alchaic was to the Professor's left, the titular Fissure in front of him.

Behind him, Richter waved from the carriage. Then, he disappeared in a shimmer; carriage and all.

The Professor sighed and pinched the bridge of his nose.

"I hate that man," the Professor muttered. He looked over the edge of the Fissure. It wasn't a red day, the river of lava dim and far. He surveyed the area - at the widest, the Fissure was over a mile wide, but it would often come close to a

couple yards.

It was irregular, unnatural, the site of many battles and the exhaust of Mount Alchaic.

That made it a very ideal place to dispose of people. The Professor walked up the Fissures, towards the mountain. He kept an eye out, both for anything out of the ordinary and for other people in general.

This wasn't a good area to be in, the Professor's presence already drawing a crowd. Not an overt one, but in the various huts and dilapidated homes, people were peeking out.

The Professor's robes were unmistakable as someone of power. Someone of import. And if they get lucky, they would obtain some of that power.

That was if they got lucky. But the Professor wouldn't give them the change. He wore a focused scowl and met the eyes of any who would look at him. They withered under his stare. Word eventually spread and when the Professor was marked as a difficult target, the crowds dispersed.

He reached one of the points in the Fissure where the cliffs weren't as steep. Houses were built into the side, but were rarely inhabited due to the ebb and flow of liquid rock.

Meaning they were good places to hide something.

The Professor scaled the rock, descending to the collection of houses. No one was in them, as he expected. And as he explored and investigated, he didn't find

anyone or anything of note. Well, he did find people. But they were skin and bones, waiting to die away from prying eyes.

At one time, the Professor felt pity for them. Perhaps he still does. But he didn't fight for them anymore. He let them give up in peace.

When he came across most of the houses on his side of the Fissure, he looked at the other side and contemplated going over.

The sun was setting now, drawing long shadows. The Professor turned to go when he saw a glimmer of light from the other side.

He sighed. The Professor turned his back to the cliff side and looked for a way to cross. Not from this area, at least not easily. The hard way it is then.

The Professor scaled the cliffs and returned to the top of the Fissures. He bounced on his feet a little bit, loosening his joints. He also tied up his robe, making sure it didn't hinder his mobility. Then, the Professor walked a little way away from the edge. Taking breaths in and out, he shook his head.

Then, he took off in a run. At the very edge, the Professor jumped. He spotted his landing - a cracked house with an opening just large enough for him. His aim was true, dropping inside with a roll. He hit the other end of the wall, but he made it intact. He jumped to his feet, blood pumping and dusted himself off.

The added adrenaline spiked his senses and he felt an unease. He recognized the sign. Bad magic. He wasn't sure what kind.

The Professor wrung his wrist. With this stunt, it's unlikely that he wasn't spotted, so the Professor eschewed stealth.

He walked from house to house, as systematic as he did before. There wasn't anyone on this side, not even anyone waiting to die.

When the Professor reached the last house on this side, he frowned. He wrung his wrist and flexed his right hand. The sun was gone now, the Professor almost in total darkness if not for the dim red light from below.

Which would mean that any self-respecting assassin would strike any moment now.

A beat passed, then another. The Professor relaxed.

Then just as quickly, he whipped and grabbed someone's wrist just before they struck him. The Professor moved quickly, throwing a punch at his assailant's gut, then another at where he assumed their head was. He threw them over his shoulder and left a foot on them as he kept their arm trapped.

"Speak," the Professor commanded. "Who are you, what do you want?"

The hand was glowing a ghastly, ethereal, blue. A siphon.

"Master," a raspy voice like gravel through a blender spoke to him. "You have not lost your touch."

"That narrows the who down considerably," the Professor pushed his foot downward. "Talk."

The voice chuckled, a scraping sound

that pained the Professor's ears.

"You will know, in time," the body turned into sand at in the Professor's hands. The sand moved to the door and reformed into a person. They were sickly and pale, skin and flesh falling off the bone. "You recognize this, don't you?"

"Aetheric poisoning," the Professor said. "A condition where the magic within you is rejected, the magic you create breaking down your cells."

"Correct," the man smiled a ghastly smile.

"It's fatal," the Professor frowned.

"It was fatal," he corrected. "I'm living proof."

"You call this living?" the Professor raised his fists and took a fighting stance. "All you are is a parasitic corpse."

"Such a mean thing to say to your dearest protege," the man said. "If you help me, I can be so much more than this. You can be so much more than that."

"Try again in another life," the Professor growled. "You've already made your decision and I've made mine."

The man shook his head. "Expected. But I am still disappointed."

The Professor took a swing, but his fist hit nothing as the man disappeared into sand once more.

"We will meet again, Professor [*****]. And I will do what you cannot."

The voice left and the unease in the air disappeared. But the unease in his chest didn't.

The Professor climbed the way out of the Fissures with his thoughts spinning. Once again, instead of going to a home in residential, he made his way back to the Chandlery.

He didn't look over his shoulder, at least not openly. He kept an ear out for anything strange. Additionally, right before he entered the Chandlery, he made a detour to the public showers. The Professor was careful to wash himself of any errant sand particles. Anything on his person, or anything in his clothes.

Only then, did he return to his office. He sat down at his desk and fiddled with the papers in front of him unsuccessfully. First the issue with Ashen's energy crisis, then the issue of the High Houses, and then an issue with literal ghosts from his past trying to pick a fight.

He knew they were all connected. All balled up into a knot. He just needed to unravel it correctly.

Easier said than done. The Professor shot to his feet and started wandering the halls as he wrestled with his next steps. Eventually, he settled on the library. The Chandlery, much like the city, never fully slept, so even well into night, it was still full of students and faculty alike.

He found what he was looking for, a young boy with blue eyes reading textbooks that were far too advanced for him. Litwick Yewl was by his side, explaining concepts with the patience of a saint.

The Professor watched for a moment, then two moments. Then he hardened his resolve and disappeared into the night.

"You seem stressed, Professor."

It's been another handful of days since the Professor's encounter with House Richter and the phantom of his past. He kept tabs on the project via the Seer, appraising their progress as necessary. The High Houses have not sent anyone else after Richter.

The lack of news did nothing to take the Professor of edge.

So it was, when Litwick Yewl asked the Professor for some advise, they made their observation with a chipper tone and a spring in their step.

"With the shenanigans thrown upon me, I would imagine this is my default state of being," the Professor replied, the two of them walking the halls of the Chandlery. They lead him to one of the practice chambers, no doubt wanting the Professor to critique something.

"Nah," Yewl grinned. "You usually have got somewhere between a tired scowl and a smug coolness. Now it's just the scowl."

"Do I scowl?" The Professor raised a brow. "Am I scowling right now?"

"No one's told you? You've got this energy that screams 'I'm super important and super busy' and a furrowed brow that could kill someone."

The Professor touched his brow and it was indeed, furrowed. He kind of knew what that entailed - it kept him out of trouble so he couldn't complain too much.

"Is that why I only get rung up in case of emergencies?" The Professor asked.

"Of course!" Yewl laughed. "Everyone always talks about how you're so scary and

go to the other Professors or Litwicks to deal with your assignments."

The Professor thought back to when Yewl first came by for assistance. He thought it was weird they were the only one, but thought nothing of it. But if she was the only one...

"Yewl, do others think of you as my Protege?" The Professor asked.

"Yeah," Yewl said. "The other Professors were quite surprised, as were the Litwicks before me when I said I was coming to you for help. Told me you weren't taking any since the 'incident', whatever that means."

"I don't remember officially taking you on," the Professor said.

"Well, you're the only one who didn't say my theories were wrong, so that's gotta count for something," Yewl stopped at the doors before the practice rooms. "And now you've got a second one too." She opened the door, beckoning for him to go first.

"A second... I see," the Professor, confused at first, saw a young boy in the practice room. Dummies were thrown around him and he stood in place, cold air visible around him. "You're not the one who needs help, are you?"

"Well," Yewl looked to the side and touched the golden cracks in their skin. "I do need some help, but when I saw the young Kirisame here, I figured I'd pull double duty."

The Professor sighed, but Yewl's enthusiasm was only slightly infectious and the corners of his mouth quirked into

a smile.

"Alright, young protege," the Professor shoosed them away. "I'll see what the boy is up to then we'll deal with your stuff."

"The boy's got a name," Yewl scoffed, but she was already moving to her own practice chamber, setting up some dummies.

The Professor entered the practice chamber, immediately feeling the cold the young boy was emitting. He bundled up his robes - the natural enchantments on it will stave off the worst.

"Young Kirisame, chilly day today, isn't it?" the Professor called out to the young boy.

The cold abated a little. The tilted his head in acknowledgment of the Professor, but otherwise kept his gaze forward. Ahead of him, the dummies he set up were starting to freeze.

"Good control for a boy your age," the Professor commented, walking up behind him.

Their robes were the bright and fresh of a young and new wick, though by now they have since been frosted over. The boy didn't respond, instead opting to completely swamp the practice room in jagged ice.

The boy breathed out, the cold frosting the air in front of him. Then, he stood there in silence for a moment too long.

"Alright, young Kirisame," the Professor set a firm hand on his shoulder. Firmly, but gently, he turned him so that young Kirisame was facing him. The Professor dropped to his knee so that they were the same height. "What ails you?"

The young Kirisame didn't answer. He stayed stoic and then looked away.

"Hey," the Professor softened his voice. The Professor knew the boy's circumstances. He could guess the issue now. That wouldn't do, however. Keeping his patience, the Professor waited until the young Kirisame looked at him. The stoic in his eyes wavered and sniffed back a tear.

"When's he coming back?" The young boy asked.

The Professor grimaced inwardly, not letting that show on his own face.

"I don't know, Jude," the Professor used the boy's name. "Your father had to leave the city because he fought for what he believed in. When the heat dies down, I'll let him know he can come back and he will."

"Did he fight because of me?" Jude asked. "Is it my fault?"

"He fought for you," the Professor said. "But it's not your fault. It was never your fault."

The boy looked unconvinced.

"He would've wanted you to have a good education," the Professor changed the subject. "How goes your studies?"

The young Kirisame's brightened a little. "Good. It's easy."

"Easy, eh?" The Professor thought back to the night he saw the Yewl and him in the library. "That's good. The fundamentals *should* be easy. The fundamentals are everything."

The boy nodded.

"Now, tell me what you're practicing," the Professor stood and looked over at the ice.

"Control," the young Kirisame said. He pointed at the glacier in front of them. "It's too much."

"Control is much harder," the Professor said with noted approval. "Do you know your limits?"

The boy thought for a moment, then shook his head.

"Then we have to find them," The Professor looked at the glacier. "You said that was too much. To me, it sounds like it's not enough. Take it away."

The Young Kirisame nodded and closed his eyes. He breathed deep and exhaled. The ice melted with each breath. When the ice cleared, the boy looked at the Professor for his next instructions.

"Limits come in all sorts," the Professor explained. He held up three fingers. "The first is size. How big you can go. The second is speed, how fast you can make it. The third is power. It'll vary based on your magic, but for ice, we can use density as a metric." The Professor paused, thought for a moment, then added, "There's a fourth one, but it's nebulous and confusing, so we'll ignore it for now."

The Professor watched him go through all the basic steps of magic.

A calming center, focus the mind. The boy took a deep breath and closed his eyes.

Good, he was using all of his focus.

Create a circle. The wind whipped up, a

small circle of ice forming around his feet.

Next, focus the magic. Ice and frost chilled around within the circle the boy created. The magic pulsed, a wave emanating outward but not breaking the circle yet.

The Professor noted that down - a circle is only as strong as the caster. If magic was spilling before it was ready, then it would mean the caster's latent potential is stronger than their control.

The boy kept pulling more and more ice.

From the entrance to the chamber, a warning alarm beeped.

"Rapidly approaching the limit the chamber can take," the Professor noted aloud. "Can you keep going?"

The boy nodded. Though his focus was wavering, he didn't look that pressed.

"Alright, that will have to do," the Professor said. "Let's see what that looks like."

The young Kirisame breathed out and the ice beneath him broke. The torrent of magic flooded in front of him and a glacier of ice shattered upon the opposite wall. The ice blossomed and bloomed, growing until the jagged edges were right in front of their faces. Maybe even further, if the young Kirisame didn't stop it with a hand.

"Not bad," The Professor let out a low whistle. "I'll have to take you to the open air practice chambers - it'll do you good to meet someone on a similar power scale."

The Professor modified his internal

appraisal of the boy. No wonder his father was adamant he become a student here.

However he was also wary. He'd seen talent, he'd seen potential. He'd seen every single one of those rising stars burn themselves out. He could see that pattern emerge in the young Kirisame. The long nights studying and the hard work in practice.

A thought occurred to the Professor.

"Jude, can you control raw magic?" the Professor asked.

The boy sighed and the ice started to melt. He shook his head no.

"Still?" the Professor raised his brow. "We'll have to see the nurses. You should have recovered by now."

The boy nodded. He looked unconvinced. He turned back to his dummies.

The Professor thought of what to say. Of the words that could be used to reassure the boy that everything would be ok. He couldn't think of them.

"I'm here for you," the Professor settled on those words and walked out of the chamber, unsure if they met their mark. In a different chamber, he found Yewl in their trance, golden magic flowing around the chamber.

He stepped inside, his presence not affecting the flow. Mages who can *trance* enter a deeper flow and can control much more magic than able. It comes with a risk, of course. He looked at their arms and at their face, at the glowing lines that glowed gold.

"Methinks your vessel needs more time to be repaired," the Professor said. "When

you said you were practicing, I was expecting fundamentals."

"This is also important," Yewl said. They waved their hands and parted the sea of magic to create a path for the Professor. They didn't need to, but it was a kindness that the Professor appreciated. "It's like making sure a broken arm still works."

The Professor shrugged.

"I think he'd benefit from more direct guidance," Yewl changed the subject.

"Sure he does," the Professor looked out of the chamber to the young boy practicing on his own. "You're doing an excellent job of providing it."

"Different guidance," Yewl said. "Life guidance. Magic is one thing, but what he's going through is another."

"I can't," the Professor shook his head. "The wicks I mentor don't get very far."

"I hear they get very far," Yewl took a deep breath and dispelled the magic around them. The gold faded from their eyes and they dusted themselves off. "Especially since it's your throw."

"That's not as assuring as it sounds," the Professor sighed.

A moment passed, then two. Yewl fiddled with a spell.

"How's your thesis?" it was the Professor's turn to change the subject.

"Good!" Yewl finished their spell. Magic poured out of them and opened a portal to a different plane. Fire and brimstone emanated from it and the two of them watched the inhabitants lumber by.

Red skinned devils and scaled monsters passed by the portal. They looked through, curious at first.

Then one of them lunged.

Yewl closed the portal just as quick, cutting the monster in half as its head landed in front of them. Blue blood oozed onto the ground.

"And that's supposed to be good?" The Professor wiped the blood from his face.

"Intraplanar travel isn't that difficult and neither is summoning," Yewl picked up the head and studied it. "Making clothes that'll protect us from the denizens in there is another thing entirely."

"Sure," the Professor said, though he didn't hide the doubt in his voice.

"I could use some help in devising the runes and bindings," Yewl followed up.

"I'm sure you could," the Professor took that as his cue. He turned for the door.

"Is that how you're going to treat your newest protege?" Yewl called out to him.

"That's how I treat my second newest protege," The Professor waved them away and went back to the young Kirisame's chamber. The boy had just finished melting all of the ice. "Keep up your studies and stick close to Litwick Yewl, we'll do your checkup in a week."

The boy nodded and that was enough for the Professor to be satisfied.

On his way out of the practice rooms, the Professor took a deep breath and felt his shoulders slump.

Then he cracked his neck and stretched his back.

"Ok," he said to himself. "Let's do this right."

The Professor lectured his class with the same ordered exactness he did with everything else in life. He gave everyone the facts, clarified any misunderstandings, and then gave appropriate projects to further their studies.

It was incredibly hard, or so he was told. Still, he hadn't heard complaints further than that so continued with his process.

Exacting, but not inflexible. That was the energy he hoped he gave off as he explained to his wicks the basics to bending reality to their will.

"As we've gone over the three methods to measure your magic, there is a fourth," the Professor held four fingers up. "It comes under many names. Strength of Will, Bravery, Gumption. I call it Conviction. You must believe that the magic is necessary before the world will bend. If you can't do that, you won't do anything else."

A hand shot up from the middle.

"You, five o'clock shadow," the Professor pointed and beckoned them to speak.

"Professor, if it's just belief, then why do we learn these runes and glyphs?"

"That's an excellent question," the Professor grabbed his chalk and pointed at him. He furrowed his brow and made a show of focusing. Then after a moment, he shouted and clapped his hands. "**Fireball.**"

The room was shocked into motion as those who could cast magic threw up a shield.

Yet nothing happened. Those in the know didn't move and wore smug grins.

When the room calmed down, the Professor set the chalk down and flourished his hands.

"Runes and glyphs are more like rules and guidelines," the Professor explained. "Reality tends to like to stay that way and your subconscious mind will do various hoops to oblige it. Spells allow you to convince yourself and reality both."

Another hand shot up.

"Shoot," the Professor guessed the next question, but wanted to hear it anyway.

"If I believe enough, can I do magic without spells?"

The Professor walked away from the lecture board and his face became deathly serious.

"Correct," the Professor said. "But let me ask you this- if everyone can cast magic as easy as breathing, what would that mean for us?"

"Magic would be easier," the student replied.

"It would be," the Professor said. "But imagine a child throwing a tantrum. Imagine a disgruntled student upset at me. Imagine a disagreement in a store."

Understanding dawned on their face.

"Magic without a guideline runs the risk of breaking our world in half," the Professor said. A knock on the door followed by a different set of students waving inside told the Professor his time in the lecture hall was out. "Before I leave you to your projects, know this; hold fast to your convictions, but know

what your convictions are."

He relinquished the room and moved through the Chandlery with purpose. The Professor stopped by his office and dropped off his stack of papers. The shadows across his window told him that he had some time before dusk. Making good time so far.

The Seer was waiting for him outside of the Chandlery, like before.

"Good afternoon, Professor," the Seer greeted. "All is well?"

"Well enough, Seer," the Professor said. "Any difficulties from the High Houses?"

"Less than I expected. The ones that arrived I were able to deal with."

"Good, good," the Professor took stock of the young man. "Let's get moving."

"As you wish," the Seer opened a portal and the two of them moved through and entered a different room. Instead of the congregation, they entered a researcher's lab. Small prototypes were strewn over tables and papers were scattered or stacked, depending on who they belonged to. Researchers moved and discussed. There was an order in the room. A chaotic order, but order nonetheless. "Without the Houses breathing down our neck, Marka has been able to move heaven and earth."

"Marka tends to work better with mid-level pressure," the Professor said. "Deadlines are good, but threats to her person have the opposite effect."

"She'll never admit to that," the Seer noted.

"So your eyes have been opened to her

pride as well," the Professor nodded with approval. "Good, there's hope for you yet, Seer."

The Professor navigated through the various researchers and discussions. He took note of their designs and their troubles. For much of it, he held his tongue and was more than content to let them run the project on their own.

"Where is Marka? Is she in engineering?" the Professor asked.

"That's correct, Professor," the Seer replied. "The hardest job goes to her, or so she says."

"So she says," the Professor idly repeated. He started to head to engineer but paused. "Seer, I need you to do something for me."

"Of course, Professor, what do you need?"

"Take my hand," the Professor held his hand out for a handshake. "I'm thinking of a person. I give you permission to find the details of this person in my mind, then find this person in Ashen."

"As you wish," the Seer took his hand and platinum eyes flashed white. The Professor felt a presence in his head and let him through- it wouldn't do to give permission and then refuse. Within seconds, however, the presence left. The Seer let go of his hand the Professor's hand. "Obtained."

"Thank you, Master Seer," the Professor did a short bow. "In my advanced age, I sometimes forget that you are an accomplished Master in your own right."

"Of course, Master Professor," the Seer

returned the bow. "I'll need a moment to find your mystery person. Five, ten minutes."

"Good, gives me time to check on Marka," the Professor moved to the endless hallways. Engineering and Research tend to be close to each other.

A couple turns and an even longer hallway and he found another door. The Professor didn't bother knocking and just entered the room.

Reaction took over as the door closed and he dropped down and ducked.

A thump hit the door behind him as the Professor looked around.

Sliding down the door was a clay ball, probably with the same intensity as a cannon.

"You ought to be more careful, Professor," Deeper in the room, Marka was working away. She hadn't even turned. "Has your time away made you forget your manners?"

"This from the woman who almost killed a man," the Professor got up and dusted himself off.

"I've killed many men," Marka snorted. "I don't know if it's a testament to my failure or your stubbornness that I keep missing this one. Why are you here?"

"Appeasing the chain around our neck," the Professor approached. When he got within a certain distance, the smell hit him like a truck. The smell of iron and flesh.

He stood next to Marka. Her normal researchers robes were replaced with a white lab coat, yet calling it white would

be incorrect. They were stained with the blood and viscera of the bodies in front of her.

The Professor didn't bat an eye at her work, though his lips were shut in a grim line.

"Don't look at me like that," Marka chided. "We knew what this project entailed. Our bodies can hold an incredible amount of magic when alive. Perhaps even in death. We're the only material that makes sense."

"And now you're sorting them," the Professor gestured over the mess in front of them.

"Bones, skin, muscle, blood and blood vessels," Marka pointed to a couple of clay containers, each filled with what she mentioned.

"Organs and extremities?"

Marka gestured beside her. She made another gesture and from the back of the room, a clay bump shifted the ground over and spat out another cadaver. She took a deep breath and then went to work.

With magic and hands, she took the cadaver apart. First the skin, then the sinew. She split muscle from bone and pulled the blood vessels out where she could. Even after being parted from life for so long, the muscles rippled and spasmed.

She finished the body and called for the next one from her clay servant. "Leave me to my work, Professor. Unless you plan on getting your hands dirty yourself."

The Professor obliged her, but not before gripping her shoulder. A

meaningless gesture, in the long run. But a gesture of faith all the same.

He stepped outside of the room and paused. Right on cue, another wave of exhaustion hit him all at once. He slumped against the door and collapsed, sitting against it as he breathed deep.

Deep breaths. Focus. The next task.

The Professor pushed himself to his feet and scowled. He felt for the furrow in his brow and with it he held onto his strength.

He needed to get back to the Seer. He'd be able to solve a problem, at the very least. Even if it's not the problem.

So with purpose and renewed drive, the Professor headed back to the other researchers. The long hallways and many turns of the labyrinth seemed to go on forever.

The Professor stopped. These hallways went far longer than they should.

Slowly, with deliberate practice, the Professor rolled up his sleeves. He tired up his robe in such a way where the fabric wouldn't inhibit his mobility.

"You know," the Professor took a step forward. "If you wanted to have a conversation, I could do it without all the smoke and mirrors."

No response.

The Professor sighed and shook his head. Whoever his assailant was, it would've made life simple if they revealed themselves then and there.

"Which means, I'm dealing with some brains or discipline," the Professor mused to himself. "Intimidation from one of the

high houses, perhaps? Surely it couldn't be the maverick. No, we've already ruled out the undisciplined."

While walking, he set his hand against the walls and pushed. The wall gave way a little bit, as if it was a sponge.

He ruled out an actual location within Ashen, which set his thoughts onto illusion, subspace, or dream. The Professor pushed his boundaries further; pressing his hand into the spongy walls.

"The trickiest thing about putting someone in a dream is perpetuation," the Professor spoke aloud. The professor in him couldn't help but explain. "The longer it goes on, the more likely things won't make sense. To most people, their brain smooths over the discrepancies."

The Professor gripped the wall, pulling it with him as he walked forward. The white and sterile walls stretched as far as they could.

"But if the dreamer is aware, then they can break the dream apart," the Professor ripped the walls that chafed on him so. The hallways around him collapsed and disappeared and was replaced with darkness.

He expected to wake up then. To find himself back in Research Labyrinth. But instead, there was darkness. All was still.

"And when a caster shoves someone into a dream, they might be entirely skilled enough to trap them regardless," the Professor muttered to himself.

Once, the Professor would've been able to target the spell itself and break

himself out. He flexed his right hand. Once.

"I should have stayed retired," the Professor sighed. He laid on his back and closed his eyes. Outwardly, he maintained a calm demeanor.

Inwardly, he went over hypotheses and tests to break free of his situation. He entertained all of them methodically and came to the same conclusion every time.

Without being able to use magic, he was stuck. He thought back to the lecture earlier. If he just believed hard enough, perhaps that would work.

"Delusional," the Professor muttered. "Delusional and hypocritical."

The Professor didn't give up. He was waiting for an opportunity. He couldn't do anything else. He can't do anything else.

The Professor didn't give up, but his heart pounding in his ears made him feel like he did.

The Professor didn't know how long he laid there. He didn't keep track. But he knew he was there for a while. He kept his thoughts still so when he heard a whisper, he couldn't help but feel a little annoyed. He wanted to keep things still, so any stray thought would have been tantamount to a failure in his discipline.

The whisper came by again.

The Professor didn't shoo it away this time. If it wasn't coming from him, it must be coming from outside. Friend or foe?

He decided it didn't matter. If his foe was foolish enough to step within mental distance of his own mind, they'd find themselves as the entertainment he sorely needed.

"Professor," the whisper insisted on something. The Professor pondered on it. Then the whisper turned to a shout. "Professor!"

The Professor's eyes shot open and on reflex, he jumped into action. His body, once prone, flew into the air. There were two figures beside him. He struck at both, one with his foot while going up, another with a fist while going down.

He impacted a magic wall both times; just as he was about to go for another swing, the Professor saw his surroundings and the two figures.

The Professor standing on a bed in a doctor's office. He recognized it as the medical bay in the Labyrinth. The Seer and Marka were next to the bed, a translucent barrier in front of them.

The Seer looked worried, though Marka

was more annoyed than anything else.

"I find you passed out in front of my door and this is how you repay me?" Marka said.

"I..." the Professor relaxed and sat down. "I don't want to hear that from someone who shot a cannon towards my head not even five minutes ago."

"Try five hours ago," Marka snorted.

"Five hours ago then," the Professor said. Then he added, "Thank you, Marka."

Marka shrugged. Then she left.

"I assume I have you to thank for breaking me from that," the Professor turned to the Seer.

"You were under an enchantment," the Seer nodded and explained. "One with a couple days of delay."

"The source?"

The Seer gestured to the beside. Atop a silver tray were several grains of sand.

The Professor pinched the bridge of his nose. He felt more sand by his eyes and scowled. Wiping the rest away, he readjusted his assumptions.

"So the maverick is capable of a lighter touch," the Professor said. "He's learned much the past couple of years."

"Am I to assume this is the same person you bid me to find?"

"Good assumption," the Professor got off the bed and stretched his limbs.

"Perhaps. Either he did this on his own and have become significantly more dangerous or he had help and we have to deal with two people instead of one. Did you find them?"

"They're in the Reds, by the Vei Chateau," the Seer said.

The Professor turned his nose up at that. House Vei was another one of the high houses, though if Richter was more militaristic, Vei specialized in entertainment. Their Chateau is one of the more popular establishments in the Ashen Red Light district- Reds for short.

"A respectable distance away from the Fissures," the Professor noted. "But more high profile than I would've thought."

"Professor, you should know," the Seer paused. He opened his mouth for the words, then shut them again. He settled on something. "You should know that when I sought them, I found an unsettling energy. Multiple souls but one figure."

The Professor grimaced. That's much worse.

"Then I best strike first and strike fast while it is only multiple and not an army's worth," the Professor said.

"If it comes to that I can help," the Seer offered. "My charge is to the project, but if it comes to the safety of Ashen I can supersede it with-"

The Professor held a hand up and bid the Seer to stop. "Not now, not yet."

"Master Professor, I must insist on this," the Seer said. "I'm not about to let pride endanger people."

"It's not pride," the Professor said. "It's responsibility. My responsibility."

"That is pride with extra steps," the Seer said.

"Ashen won't see it that way," the Professor refuted. "Send me out of the

Labyrinth. That's how you can help for now."

The Seer frowned, but did what was asked of him. The portal opened to the darkness outside of the western side of Ashen. Through it, the Professor can see the last embers of the sun over the horizon.

"I don't agree with this," the Seer said. "This isn't something you should do alone."

"When you've make the same mistakes I have, then you'll understand," the Professor bowed to the Seer. "I thank you again, Master Seer. You will have news from me soon."

And then the Professor stepped through.

The moment he did, crisp and clear air from the night outside rejuvenated the Professor just a little bit. The sterile air of the Labyrinth was something he never liked and he found a bounce to his step as he moved down the mountain.

It was a night where the Fissures was more active. To his south, the Professor could see the deep red glow of the magma.

He moved to the second brightest red light in the distance. The Reds.

This area was more populated then the Fissures. By a lot. The crowds blended in together and he was often shoulder to shoulder with whoever was coming out of parlors, clubs, or bars. Magical residue filled the air like smoke, not to mention the actual smoke.

The Professor dove his way through the crowds and disappeared in them. Despite the way the Chandlery and his Chandlery

robes were considered a higher place of learning, the robes weren't exactly out of place either. Other students and faculty were here as well.

In Ashen, few things were quite like getting high. Even fewer were magical highs.

The crowds died down a little bit as he approached the Vei Chateau. This area was more quiet, less lit, services more expensive. It could afford to be, the clients far more wealthy and influential.

No wonder, since the proximity to one of the High Houses serves as the main draw.

It was no surprise to the Professor when the guards in front of the gated Chateau raised their spears at him.

"State your business," they asked.

"The Professor wishes an audience with House Vei," the Professor said. "*Brave the Ashy Climb.*"

The guards nodded and spoke into a rune. The rune buzzed with activity and the guards flinched, then apologized into the rune.

"*The Ashes Fall still,*" the guard replied and opened the gate. The two of them bowed to the Professor, who bowed back. "My lord and lady both await you in the study."

"Of course," the Professor walked through. Once he was halfway through the front garden, he started to roll up his sleeves. The lights of the Chateau were sparse. From the outside, very few rooms were lit. Even the garden were missing

magelights.

It was eerie. So the Professor put down two theories. Either House Vei is prepared for this contingency and are already prepared or his maverick protege already did what they came here to do and the guards didn't know better.

In either case, the Professor made it to the front door and knocked. The door opened on its own with a creak.

"No escort, no inner guards, no lights," the Professor spoke aloud again. It was something he couldn't truly help. "I'm starting to think the great House Vei has been sundered in two."

No response, similar to his dream.

The Professor sighed and walked inside. The Chateau was still. He kept his eyes and ears open and trained, ready to jump at shadows.

The layout of the Chateau was familiar enough to him - the study was in the west wing of the second floor. The steps creaked as he walked up the stairs.

Slowly, calmly, he walked through the still halls.

He hadn't seen a single soul and couldn't help but wonder what happened to this house. The Professor made it to the door of the study without any sign of his protege.

He reached to knock.

Before he could, the door opened and a staff shoved itself into his face. Fire and magic collected at the tip.

The Professor moved faster, grabbing onto the staff and pulling it past him just as the magic swelled. He forced the

door open with and almost punched the owner until a second magical presence grabbed his body and threw him inside.

"Ashes bury me," a familiar voice said. The door shut with a slam and several wards were replaced onto it. "Are you mad, Professor? A situation like this and you just waltz in and announce yourself?"

The Professor reoriented himself.

Wielding the staff was the Lady Nara Vei, a shorter woman with black eyes. The warder and also the one who pulled the Professor in was the Lord Nao Vei, a taller man with blue eyes. Offense and defense in a pair.

"Well your guards let me in," the Professor said. "Bereft of information, I played the part of the fool."

"Played," Lady Nara rolled her eyes. "More like were the fool. Age has not granted you wisdom, I see."

The Professor shrugged.

Lady Nara stepped close and squinted at the Professor.

"Your talents are wasted on you," Lady Nara said.

"You have made that abundantly clear in the past," the Professor replied. He looked over to Lord Nao, who shrugged as well. "So? What's the situation? I could only imagine you've been threatened."

"We were attacked at our busiest time. Nao has already transported guests and services to a different location," Lady Nara then added, "At a location that will remain undisclosed. We lost two guards, a member of the house, but thankfully no guests."

"A small mercy," Lord Nao said. "If they were more focused, we would've lost a lot more. Even as it stands, we have a lot injured."

"Where are they now?" the Professor said.

"Somewhere in the Chateau," Lord Nao cast a sidelong glance to the Professor. "If you're already here, I presume you know the threat."

"Something of that nature, yes," the Professor said.

Lady Nara squinted at him, then her staff lit with magical fire.

"Richter that lying snake," she said. "So that's what he met you for. Then that must mean—" The fire on her staff burned white hot.

The Professor glanced at Lord Nao, who made no movement. He analyzed the spell and made quick guesswork of what he'd need to do to neutralize it if it came down to it. First distract Lord Nao somehow, then close the gap to Lady Nara and disarm her. He'd have to move fast.

Then the fire simmered, yet remained white hot.

"Which protege is it," Lady Nara asked through grit teeth.

"Allen Moled," the Professor said.

"Your most recent one," Lord Nao said. "I thought he burned."

"As did I," the Professor flexed his right hand. "He's siphoning energy from the living to keep himself afloat. As far as souls."

"Ashes bury me," Lady Nara swore. "As

if your mistake couldn't cost you just your magic, now it's costing us as well."

"Ok Nara, you've made your displeasure clear," Lord Nao finally stepped in.

"Professor [*****]" - the Professor winced - "has already come here in good faith to help us. We can collect on this debt now instead of later."

The Professor could see Lady Nara grind her teeth, but she refrained from speaking further. The magic in her staff did not abate.

"So Professor," Lord Nao gestured to the door. "What can you tell us? Is there anyway his Folly can help us?"

Folly. The Professor mulled over the concept for a moment. Every respectable mage has one. Longer lived mages can have multiple. But despite being a badge every respectable mage has, it was often a badge of shame.

Aptly named, it marks whenever the mage overreached. Overreached egregiously, often fatally. The Professor did have one.

"His Folly would have no tangible use to us," the Professor said. "If anything, it's of more use to him. He's forsaken the rules of magic. It's burning through him quickly, but that's what he's replenishing his own energy for."

"If we're careful, we can try to exhaust him," Lord Nao said.

"Most likely," the Professor said. "But he's a madman who can bend reality to his will. It will be dangerous."

"This from the man who waltzed in with nary a care in the world," Lady Nara quipped.

Lord Nao shushed her.

"Surely you have a better plan," Lord Nao said. "If my partner is correct, you walked here and provoked him. Either him or us."

"Make no mistake, he's unstable," the Professor said. "Incredibly so. Of course, while unstableness makes him dangerous, it makes him pliable."

"And you can ply?" Lord Nao asked. "In your condition?"

"I can no longer feel the flow of magic, but I can recognize it when it comes," the Professor said. "I can be bait."

"And you're sure that he'll bite?" Lord Nao appeared doubtful.

"Of course," the Professor nodded. He cracked his knuckles and stretches his back. Truthfully, the Professor only had the words in his mind and outdated information. But that wasn't what the three of them needed at this moment. What they needed was action. "Are you two ready? I'll step out first. When I reach the main foyer, stay in the wings until he attacks me. That'll be your chance."

"Very well," Lord Nao nodded to Lady Nara. "Fire and faith, my lady."

"Fire and faith," Lady Nara returned the chant. The staff blazed a holy white. She grimaced at the Professor, then gestured him onward.

The Professor opened the door and walked out. He didn't sneak or have care in his steps. He stance tall and his chest out, the Professor strode back through the wing of the Château.

If his protege was still here, no doubt he was watching. If he is, then this is what he'd expect. If he isn't... Well, the Professor wasn't one to make himself look like a fool for no reason.

He reached the foyer and stopped at the top of the stairs.

"So Allen, how did you do it?" the Professor asked the empty Chateau. "How did you survive? It's been five years since then."

He started walked down it.

"I thought you were really gonna do it, you know," the Professor punctuated each sentence with a step. He kept a hand on the railing. "Solve the energy problem, I mean. Your growth was revolutionary at the time. Was."

Halfway down the stairs, the air changed. There it is.

"Little did I know that you were nothing more than a thief," the Professor kept talking. "A liar. A hypocrite."

Pressure filled the room.

"Even now, you're nothing more than a parasite," The Professor reached the bottom of the stairs. Sand blew in from the wings and the rooms. "So let me make a guess to your survival."

The sand coalesced into a person.

"When you challenged the Archmage of War, you truly didn't account for the gap between the two of you," the Professor said. "And right when he shattered you, you shattered yourself. You became sand."

Allen appeared from the sand, several orbs of light pulsing within his frame.

"Finally. I became aether," Allen's said, the voice raspy as before. "I am freed from the confines of my flesh."

"Of course you did," the Professor shook his head. "How long until you're unable to maintain your form?"

"Indefinitely," Allen smiled a smile too wide.

"Of course," the Professor walked around his former protege. "Indefinitely. Or to be more accurate, however long it takes to burn through the magic you've siphoned. The souls you stole."

"You wound me Master." Allen turned and followed the Professor with his gaze. "Are you so different? Is Ashen?"

"Of course," the Professor stopped turning when his back was to the door. Out of the corner of his eye, the Professor saw Lord Nao waiting in the wings. He put his fists up.

"And you call me a hypocrite," Allen raised his hands to the side. Sand fell out of him. The orbs inside him began to dim as magic poured out. "Then what do you call your core? A necessary evil? No, Master. You're just hiding from the truth."

The world went still and the Professor tensed.

"That you'd do anything to cast magic again."

The Professor sprang into action at the same time the sand shot towards him. He read the lines of attack and darted to the side, then over.

He lucked out with Allen's actions. With no rules and guidelines, magic can be

used to do whatever he wanted. But the Professor played upon his Folly, his prior affinity with sand, and simple delusions.

Even if he could do whatever he wanted, the Professor knew Allen would only want to do one thing.

The Professor watched the sand pulse with magic and punched the streams. The sand fell to the ground, like a puppet losing its strings.

Magic has a certain path it takes. Like the runes in the model of Ashen, strike it at the right spot and it all falls apart.

That concept and his experience is the only reason the Professor stayed alive as someone with no magic against someone who is living aether.

He slipped through the sand and stepped closer and closer. He caught glimpses of Allen within the storm. The orbs- no. The souls within him pulsed like heartbeats. Allen kept the smile that was far too wide.

When the Professor was within arms reach of Allen, the maverick finally moved. His hands struck for the Professor's neck.

The Professor parried it away and struck with his own hands, punching Allen in the chest with all of his might. He hit something solid. The sand around his fist didn't dissipate. In fact, it gripped onto his fist and kept him there.

"Will you not aid me?" Allen asked. The Professor found the sincerity and his smile disconcerting. He tried to punch Allen's face but was met with no reaction. "I thought not."

Allen gripped the Professor's arm with his own hands. The sickly hands glowed with a blue light, falling off the bone and regenerating just as fast.

From the moment of contact, the Professor felt weaker. A searing pain exploded from within his chest. He fell to his knees, propped up by the sand keeping him there.

"In matters of expedience, I could do this instantly," Allen explained. "How long did it take you to betray me? To make sure my memory was struck from memory? How long did it take you to lose your magic? I will make sure that this will take just as long."

An invisible force grabbed onto the Professor's waist. In that same instant, Lady Nara appeared at his side. She shoved her staff into the opening in the sand. Fire crackled and burned. Searing white light exploded in the opening.

That freed the Professor, and the two of them were pulled back onto the second floor by Lord Nao.

"That was a terrible opening," Lord Nao said.

"Then I'll make another," the Professor coughed and wrung the arm that was grabbed.

The explosion scattered the sand, as well as Allen's form, but it was already starting to recuperate.

"We can't exhaust him," Lord Nao said. "Not without significant losses."

"The souls he's taken is visible in his chest," the Professor said.

"A weak point, yes I saw it," Lady Nara

dropped her staff, which melted away. She pulled out two wands from thin air and sparked them together. "Let us be about it!"

She jumped towards Allen just as the body reformed.

The Professor followed. He stumbled as he reached the first floor. Even if his protege didn't take everything, the Professor could feel portions of his vitality missing.

He grit his teeth and dashed beside Lady Nara. He still recognized the flow of magic. At the very least, that wasn't taken away from him. Sand attacked them both, but Lord Nao erected a barrier on one side, the Professor disabling sand on the other side.

Lady Nara's two wands sparked with fire and lightning. She muttered something underneath her breath, the beginnings of a spell. Fire condensed in one wand, lightning crackled in the other.

The Professor knew that if he could recognize it, so could Allen.

She fired off her spell right when they reached Allen, but he threw up a wall of sand. The sand crystallized into glass from the extreme heat, but it wasn't enough to pierce.

Allen pushed through the sand and reached out to grab Lady Nara. The Professor tackled her out of the way and Lord Nao grabbed both of them with his telekinesis.

He threw them into the air, sand chasing after them. It expanded like a giant hand surrounded them.

The Professor scanned the surrounding sand in three heartbeats. He grabbed Lady Nara's arm and pointed the wand upwards.

"Blast!" He commanded. In that same moment, the Professor kicked off the invisible force of Lord Nao's magic and dove downward.

An explosion sent the sand flying back, exposing Allen who was rising towards them with a hand outstretched. The Professor kicked the hand away and landed on Allen's face. He didn't stay long and jumped upwards before the sand could catch him.

Unbothered, Allen kept his serene smile.

Lord Nao found an opening to take the two away from the sand and reposition them on opposite sides of the foyer.

They needed more firepower. The Professor looked at the other side to Lady Nara- if she had more time, she could possibly get the job done.

The Professor could stall the sand, but not Allen himself.

He grimaced. Not for the first time, he cursed his inability to use magic. If he still had it, this situation would be very different.

The Professor shook his head. No, he had to play with the cards he had instead of the cards he doesn't.

"You're right, Allen," the Professor called out to his protege. "I miss my magic. I miss it a lot."

Allen turned to regard his former master. His smile widened.

"Every day, I think about what I need to do to get it back," the Professor said.

"How much easier things would be."

Allen opened himself up to the Professor, the sand provided a path. He held an inviting hand open to the Professor. The souls pulsed within.

The Professor kept his dukes up and continued speaking. "Maybe we are the same. But I'm not about to let that stop me from doing the right thing. That starts here."

The Professor changed his fist into a palm and gestured Allen to have the first strike.

Allen's smile contorted into a bitter roar. The Professor stood in place as sand and magic flooded the room and swirled around them both. He closed his eyes and steadied his breathing.

The Professor had one shot at this. He opened his eyes. Allen's hands were inches away from his throat, the sand a second away from entombing him.

The Professor struck faster and struck true. He drove his fist into the center of Allen's chest, right at the tip of his ribcage. Throwing his heel, his hip, and his shoulders into the punch, the Professor felt bone give and in that moment, he ducked to the side.

A lance of fire pierced the sand and Allen's upper body, right above where the Professor struck.

Something shattered like glass and sand exploded from Allen's body. A familiar lifeline wrapped around the Professor and he was pulled from the explosion, though not before suffering friction burns from all the moving sand.

Lord Nao dropped the Professor on the second floor, where Lady Nara was. The three of them watched the sand shuffle and implode on the first floor, until it eventually stilled.

Allen's body was nowhere to be found, wisps of the souls within him fading like smoke in the air.

The only sounds in the foyer were the shifting of sands and caught breaths. The Professor's adrenaline faded, his exhaustion peeking through as well as his injuries.

He watched the sand until it stilled and only then did he get up.

"That was cutting it a bit close, Professor," Lord Nao said. "I am surprised he fell for your bait. Multiple times, even."

"Even in life, Allen was hot-headed," the Professor said. "I'm surprised his talent was in earth magic and not fire." He jumped down to the foyer; the battle demolished the stairs, as well as ripped through the walls of the Chateau.

Lady Nara went with him, her wands snapped into twigs.

"I've got half a mind to foot you with the bill," Lady Nara mumbled to him.

"You'd be waiting on that payment for a while," the Professor said. He studied the sands, kicking the center of the room where Allen was. Much of the sand turned to glass from Lady Nara's high heat, a glass sculpture of a person in the middle. He studied it. There was a nagging in the back of his mind. "What am I missing?"

"Pardon?" Lady Nara furrowed her brow.

"Just earlier today, I was thrown into a dream," the Professor said. "I thought it would be Allen here, but from the beginning he wasn't very talented at delicate magic. The multiple souls would have given him that ability, but he stuck to his guns."

"You've said it yourself," Lord Nao

came down with them. "He was unstable and hot-headed. Perhaps that is why."

"Perhaps," the Professor thought back. "'Finally.' Why did he say that? It couldn't have been because I knew it was him, I tracked him down to the Fissures already."

The Professor looked at Lord Nao and Lady Nara. Lord Nao stroked his chin in thought.

"You're saying he had help," Lady Nara said what was on the Professor's mind.

"He must have," the Professor frowned and pinched the bridge of his nose. "What was this attack supposed to mean? What was the purpose?"

The nagging feeling kept growing and growing. The hypothesis hit him like lightning.

"What do you two know of the Master Seer?" the Professor suddenly asked.

"The black sheep of the Essaïm family," Lord Nao said. "Elatha Essaïm. He arrived in Ashen a couple years ago with his twin sister, Ellis Essaïm. While his sister is not much of note, Elatha is an unparalleled Seer for his young age."

"And he's taken over your position in the Core Project," Lady Nara growled. "I'm still against it. He's too young to lead it."

"Barring his age, I let him into my head to help me find Allen," the Professor said.

"You let a Seer into your head? And an Essaïm at that?" Lady Nara exclaimed. "Ashes bury me, this is the famed successor to the Archmagus?"

The Professor's hand ached at that comment.

"You've given him information to track down your protege," Lord Nao ignored his partner's outburst. "A fine idea in theory. You think he's the one who threw you into the dream?"

"I believe he's got the skill for it," the Professor kept his frown and walked around the foyer. "But what would be the gain here?" He shook his head. "No, it's too ambiguous. I'll ask him directly."

"Let's pretend that he did betray you," Lady Nara interjected. "You're going to ask this incredible Seer if he's on your side and expect him to not pounce when you reveal the ruse?"

The Professor thought about it for a moment. "I'll move faster than he does."

"Fine. Go die in a hole somewhere," Lady Nara snapped.

"What Nara means is, 'thank you for your assistance here,'" Lord Nao said. "I do think it's unwise, but I can't fault your intuition for bringing you this far." He thought for a moment, then added, "For all your intelligence, I do agree with Lady Nara that it is inadvisable."

The Professor shrugged, then held up his right hand. "Playing it smart is what got me here. Now if you will excuse me."

Lady Nara and Lord Nao didn't bar the Professor's path as he left the Chateau.

The Professor mulled over the situation. The front garden was quiet, same as before. There was an unease that he couldn't quite get rid of. He reached the front gate, yet as he the moonlight

hit him, he stopped cold in his tracks.

The two guards that greeted him in were on the ground, in a pool of their own blood. Their spears were in each other.

"A delusion," the Professor gasped. He ran back towards the Chateau.

He arrived not a moment too soon. Lord Nao had Lady Nara in the air with his magic, choking the life out of her. At the same time, lightning crackled in Lady Nara's fingertips.

The Professor tackled Lord Nao out of the way of the lightning, then struck him in the temple. The disorientation and pain was enough for him to drop the spell, Lady Nara falling back to the ground with a thump.

The two of them were unconscious, but the Professor heard the wind pick up. It blew through the Chateau, scattering the sand further. It sounded like laughter.

The Professor waited until the Lord and Lady Vei were awake and safe before leaving the Chateau properly. They were briefly confused, but the two of them recognized a delusion when they were in one. In the morning, the Professor started to head towards the Chandlery.

At the front gate, he stopped. Students and faculty passed around him. They whispered to themselves as the Professor caught his name here and there. When the Professor met their gaze, they looked away and hurried along. He wondered what they thought of the famed Professor standing there. Maybe they thought he was inspecting something important.

No, the exhaustion had caught up with

him. It's only due to his pride that he hadn't collapsed where he stood.

The Professor stood there and caught his breath. The wind picked up again. And again he heard a laughter he couldn't place.

Someone bumped into him. The Professor looked down and saw the young Kirisame on the floor, having crashed into the Professor. The young boy rubbed his head and stood back up. He wobbled as well.

"Jude? What are you doing out here?" the Professor asked him.

The boy didn't answer, but his stomach answered for him. The growl cut his silence. He looked embarrassed, but then he tugged on the Professor's robe and pointed outside of the Chandlery, towards a small cafe that hasn't opened yet.

The Professor sighed, but he couldn't help but wear a soft smile. The first smile of the day.

"Alright, I'll wait with you," the Professor said. He followed the young boy to the cafe and the two of them waited together.

The boy didn't ask for much, just some pancakes and a cup of chocolate. The Professor enjoyed his own coffee, preferring a pastry of his own.

The Professor watched him eat. At first, the Professor kept a careful eye and ear out, waiting for the wind to pick up and the laughter to follow. After yesterday's events, he was more than a little on edge.

But there was nothing of the sort. Instead, a gentle breeze lapped at his robes and tried to blow their napkins away.

He couldn't think of a calmer morning. Eventually, his shoulders relaxed and the Professor could taste the flavors in his coffee. He looked at the cafe.

"Been working in the Chandlery for half my life and this is the first time I've been here," the Professor mused to himself.

The young Kirisame looked up in acknowledgment, then went back to his pancakes. He struggled to swallow the fluff, so the Professor flagged a nearby waiter for more water.

For relaxed as the Professor felt, he noted something to himself about the boy. For once, he was more animated, eating his food with gusto and a smile. A child's smile. The Professor hadn't seen this in... well he hadn't seen it at all, even when his father was still in the city.

The thought of that caused his hand to ache. The Professor glanced in the direction of Mount Alchaic.

Oh, Jude? The roads been rough on him,

but he's got the gumption I've got.

I swear to god, Professor, they lay a finger on my boy and I will cut this city down.

The Professor believed in Jude's father then. He believed him now.

Promise me this; promise me he gets the education he deserves. The stability he needs.

When the boy finished his breakfast, the Professor noted the longing look as he stared at the empty plate.

"Alright, come on Jude," the Professor stood up, his coffee half-finished. He left some strahl on the table for the food. "We've delayed that medical checkup long enough."

Jude didn't get up right away. After a beat or two, he did, but not before looking at his plate one last time.

"We can come again some other time," the Professor said.

That perked the boy up a little bit. He didn't skip as he followed the Professor, but there was a pep in his step that wasn't there before.

The boy can be bribed with food, the Professor thought to himself. That information can be useful. He didn't know how, yet. But there was a use in there.

The two of them returned to the Chandlery and the Professor lead them to the center spire. Medical was centralized across most of the floors due to the dangers and projects running around the building. The facilities themselves were second only to Uptown, at Mount Alchaic.

The Professor checked the boy in.

"Professor! And the young Kirisame!" a bombastic woman entered the waiting room. "I was wondering when you two would come by. You should tell Litwick Yewl to take it easier, by the way."

"Asa," the Professor smiled and shook her hand. She was buff and sculpted, probably twice the Professor's size and was one of the few that the Professor suspected could break him in half. "If she won't take advice from her doctor, I doubt I'll have any effect."

"That's because you're not trying hard enough," Asa grinned and waved at the young Kirisame. "Make sure you try harder with this one, you hear me? I won't stand for losing someone with a bright future ahead of him."

"I'll keep that in mind," the Professor said.

"You better," Asa crossed her arms. "Anything less and I'll break half the bones in your body. That'll be only your hands and feet, by the way."

"Good thing I didn't need those," the Professor cleared his throat. "Now, can you pencil us in for a checkup?"

"Of course, of course!" Asa lead the two of them out of the waiting room and into her office. "You two know the drill by now, yes?"

Jude took his robes off and folded them neatly onto the doctor's table. He rolled his sleeves up and sat on the operating chair.

As for the Professor, he just took a seat at the corner and made sure to keep

out the way.

The start of the checkup went as it always did. Asa danced around Jude with various tools and monitors.

"Pulse is good, internal temp is good, external temp is-" she touched his hands then frowned. "External temp is ice cold."

"Ice affinity," the Professor said.

"Tell the kiddo he's working too hard," Asa said, then pat Jude's shoulder.

"Kiddo, you're working too hard."

The Professor nodded at the same time Jude did. Asa looked unconvinced, but she rolled her eyes and continued the checkup.

"Ok, physicals look good. A little on the lean side, so make sure you eat three square meals a day," Asa said.

"Understood," the Professor said. "He likes pancakes, or so we found out today."

Asa paused and squinted at the Professor. He shrugged.

"Why did his father make you his guardian when I don't even know if you eat?" Asa shook her head.

"You keep asking, but I don't know if the answer is ever going to change," the Professor said.

"A girl can dream!" Asa exclaimed. She pushed no further and opened the door. "Now we check your magic."

The Professor picked up the young Kirisame's robe and the three of them moved to different room. The magical study was a room split into two, separated by a viewing glass; the first half had the controls and the second half had a machine that can used several runes to test and

track someone's magical abilities. The Professor stayed in the control portion while Asa guided Jude in.

She formed the runes around him, first a magic circle on the floor as a base, then several auxiliary runes to track the several layers of magic.

Once she was satisfied with her prep, she gave Jude another pat on the head, a thumbs up, and then joined the Professor in the control room.

"Alright Jude, give me a nod when you're ready to go," Asa said.

From within the chamber, Jude nodded. He looked a little dour - the sugar rush of the breakfast must be wearing off.

"Here we go, starting with a little mana current. If you feel a tingle in your limbs, that's alright," Asa said. She summoned a glyph on the control panel, adjusted it, then activated the spell. A low hum filled Jude's room as magic flowed in. The circle glowed and wisps of crystallized dust surrounded the young boy. With each breath, the dust followed the path in and out of the boy's breathing.

"I can see the magic now, is it new?" the Professor asked.

Asa nodded. "We thought that for people who were too young to see magic, we'd color it so it's visible to the naked eye. Calms the young ones and the untalented."

"And me," the Professor noted.

"And you," Asa agreed. "Nice how many people we can tackle with a little fix, right?"

The Professor nodded.

"No blockages, smooth flow," Asa said. Then she furrowed her brow. The Professor took note of that too.

The Professor was about to speak up when something thwacked him in the back of the head. Not hard, just enough to stop him from speaking.

"Magic pathways look good," Asa said. She shot a quick glance and the Professor understood what she was trying to say. A conversation for later. "Next, we'll check your receptivity in a moment. If it gets uncomfortable in there, say or do something, alright kiddo?"

Jude nodded and sat down to get comfortable.

Asa created another glyph and adjusted the magic in the room. The dust turned in the room turned to a cloud. It thickened until the room was filled with a thick smog.

"That looks a little bad," the Professor said.

"Let me change the visual for it," Asa said. She hummed a merry tune to herself as she summoned a third glyph. The smog rippled and smoothed over until it was like Jude was underwater. "Any discomfort, kiddo?"

The boy shook his head no. He tilted his head for a moment, then shot a thumbs up, similar to the one Asa gave him before.

The Professor quirked a smile.

"We already knew he was resilient, but I initially chalked that up to his sickness," Asa muttered to herself.

"He's gotten much better since he

arrived here," the Professor said.

"That he has," Asa continued monitoring Jude's vitals. "For all intents and purposes, he's in tip-top shape. More than tip-top shape, actually."

"What do you mean?"

"We've got a powerhouse!" Asa exclaimed. She grinned at the boy in the chamber. "I reckon we can dunk you in enough magic to power a small sun and you'd come out of it without any issues."

Jude smiled.

Then she motioned for the Professor to come closer. In a lower voice, without broadcasting to other chamber, she said, "Only issue is that he's not generating magic on his own. Kind of like you, actually."

"Well, my condition is slightly more severe," the Professor said.

"Slightly," Asa rolled her eyes.

"Okie dokie, kiddo," Asa cut the magic. "The Professor and I are about to chat about your results. Nothing out of the ordinary, your sickness isn't coming back, and you should be good to go. We'll give the room a couple of minutes to equalize the aether with the outside. Wouldn't want to give your body a shock."

She shut the communication between the rooms.

"Is that all?" the Professor asked. "He can't generate his own magic?"

"Long and short of it," Asa confirmed.

"Can he sense it?" the Professor furrowed his brow.

"Should be able to," Asa nodded. "A

bigger problem is going to be sensitivity and control. If he gets hit by something delicate, I doubt he'd even notice. To use his ice as an example, his 10% would be someone else's 100%. But the difficulty stays the same."

"That's fine, we can teach him control," the Professor said. "I'm more concerned about why you're concerned."

"It's just..." Asa sat still for a moment. "Be careful, alright Professor? Especially with that one." Asa opened the door to their room and beckoned Jude inside. "I've seen too many wicks burn out and the more fuel they've got, the more explosive the burn."

As Jude came in she tussled his hair one more time.

"Ok, kiddo? Make sure you're not overdoing it too soon- if you have to overdo it, make sure you're old and gray like this guy here," Asa grinned at the Professor. "And make sure Litwick Yewl and you get some proper rest. You look awful."

The Professor tried to assuage her fears, but he knew she didn't buy it. A lifetime of otherwise would make that difficult.

While the two of them left the office, the laughing wind came again. The Professor stopped.

A powerhouse, the Professor thought back to what Asa said. He looked at the boy beside him. A powerhouse.

His hand ached again. Then the boy held it.

The Professor looked down at Jude- the boy looked worried. The Professor didn't

know if he could hear the laughter in the wind, but the Professor hoped he never had to.

"Let's get going," the Professor mustered up what little strength he had left. "Now last I remember, I was teaching you control."

It's been several weeks since then. Calm, steady weeks, with plenty of sleep. The Professor had plenty of energy, enough to take on the world.

But then again, despite plenty of rest and several scoldings from medical, his exhaustion was never due to his body.

It was the way pulse quickened whenever the wind picked up. It was when he looked twice at a shadow. It was whenever he was teaching Jude, he'd choose his words carefully.

So when he was in the outdoor practice courts with the boy and Yewl, he almost thanked the black robed mages approaching them. The Professor didn't think much of them at first, but as their numbers turned from one, to two, to four, to six, he started paying attention.

"Litwick Yewl, how's your transport?" the Professor asked out of the blue.

"A to B is ok, standard stuff," Yewl said. Their scars still weren't healed, but when he asked about it earlier, Yewl said they made them look cool.

"Instant?"

"No, travel time," Yewl tilted their head.

"Start thinking about it," the Professor said. "Jude, come here."

The boy stopped what he was doing and did what was asked, standing next to the Professor.

"Stick close to Litwick Yewl," the Professor said.

"Is there something wrong, Professor?" Yewl asked. The Professor regretted involving them in the higher politics of

the Chandlery and of Ashen, but he warned them of their involvement several times.

"Not yet," the Professor said. "But I'm going to greet out new visitors. If things go bad then I need you to take Jude somewhere safe."

"And your definition of safe is?"

"Not here," the Professor started walking away. "Don't find me, I'll find you. Don't worry, it might not come to that."

"If it does?"

"Then you'll understand why I tried not to take proteges," the Professor said.

The black robes have surrounded their part of the practice space, one of them at the entrance. The Professor approached them.

"High Houses, Archmages, or Chandlery?" the Professor asked them.

The question seemed to give the black-robed mage pause, as they didn't answer right away.

"We are here on behalf of the High Houses," their voice was hard, masculine. "House Richter is requesting us to escort the young Jude Kirisame to the labyrinth. Alone."

"For what purpose?" the Professor hardened his gaze. "As the boy's guardian, I am struggling to figure out why."

On the challenge, the robes loosened a little. There was a sword at the mage's hip. The rest of the mages followed suit, revealing spears.

"I'm not going to ask again, Professor," the mage had steel in their

voice, matching the steel at their side.

"So it would seem," the Professor weighed his options. He didn't know who any of these mages were, but the black robes and weapons didn't give him any favors.

Organized, skilled, and to the point.

"The boy goes where I go," the Professor says. "My student walks free."

"This isn't up to discussion," the mage gripped their sword.

The Professor tensed. The energy around them all turned heavy.

Then the mage's link went off. All the tension in the air went away as they pulled away and touched a finger to their ear.

"Yes sir," the mage responded and the Professor took that moment to look around. The other mages, while relaxed, kept their weapons out and energy in the air.

They were ready. The Professor's usual advantage, surprise and initiative, wouldn't help much here. So he kept waiting and hoped for good news.

"Of course sir," the mage continued the conversation. He glanced at the Professor. "Are you sure, sir? It's no bother if... Yes sir. Right away sir."

The mage cut the communication.

"You're in luck, Professor," the mage said. "House Richter will honor your request. The spirit and the letter."

"Thank you. Let me inform them," the Professor bowed his head slightly. He returned to the Yewl and the boy.

Yewl's eyes darted to each mage, but at

the Professor's approach, they looked at him for support.

"Professor, those are weapons," Yewl said.

"Yes, Litwick Yewl, I can see that," the Professor glanced around and placed a hand on their shoulder. "I've bartered for your involvement. Take a couple steps away from Jude and me, then send yourself away. It doesn't matter where. If all goes well, I'll still help you with your thesis and whatever else you need, but this protege business ends here."

Yewl nodded once, twice.

"What about you and Jude?" Yewl asked.

"Time is ticking, Professor," the mage exclaimed.

"We'll figure it out," the Professor said.

Yewl took a couple steps back.

The rest of the mages drew their weapons.

The Professor held a hand out. "They walk, that was our agreement."

"Magically?" The mage infused magic into their sword.

"Quickest way to walk," the Professor said. He nodded at Yewl. "Now get going, be well."

Yewl nodded and casted their spell. Within moments, golden light engulfed them. All of the mages prepared spells, but when the golden light turned to an orb and moved towards the sky, the spells dissipated.

The Professor breathed a sigh of relief. Solomon's word is good. If they're

following the spirit and the letter, then Yewl had no place for the games of the High Houses.

"Now come," the mage said. "We're already behind schedule."

"Stick close to me," the Professor whispered to Jude. "If things get bad, maximum ice."

The boy nodded and followed right behind the Professor, gripping onto his robes.

The Professor followed the main mage, who lead them through the Chandlery. The other mages surrounded them as a strict escort. He made a note that they were traveling on foot - either the mages were under orders not to teleport, or they were completely unable to for one reason or another.

Mages of a certain caliber should be able to cast any fundamental spell as needed, so it's not from lack of skill. Additionally, if they were under a schedule, there would be no reason to not use a teleport.

Which leads the Professor to the conclusion that wherever they needed to go, was under heavy security. Enough to deter teleportation under the banner of the High Houses. A handful of places in the Labyrinth fit that description.

High security locations where discretion is paramount. The actual Ashen Core, where energy from the leyline is harvested, would be one example. Projects belonging to the Archmages would be another.

The Professor grimaced. It didn't have

to belong to projects in particular. Prisons were another option. There were other prisons outside of the Labyrinth, but the ones within contained the most delusional mages.

"Hope that doesn't make me delusional," the Professor muttered to himself.

Jude tilted his head and tugged on the Professor's robe.

"Just a joke, hopefully," the Professor whispered to him.

The boy nodded, but otherwise kept in lockstep with the rest.

They reached the foot of Mount Alchaic and entered the Labyrinth from a side entrance.

As they walked through the sterile white walls of the Research portion of the Labyrinth, the Professor recognized where they entered from and where they were going. They were heading towards Marka and the rest of them.

The Professor furrowed his brow. Unless the Seer and Marka had a breakthrough in the past twenty-four hours, their clearance should be as usual. The Professor glanced at the boy holding on to his robe and Asa's words entered into his head.

A powerhouse, the Professor thought. Enough magic to power a small sun. Or in other words, a battery.

The Professor gripped Jude's hand. The boy's hand was cold and at this point, the Professor wasn't sure who was more worried, him or the boy.

They reached main research hall, where

the Seer teleported them into the first time. The mage knocked on the door twice and then drew a glyph. The glyph glowed once, twice, then took effect on the door. It opened to burly mage pointing a glowing staff at them. The burly mage and the mage guiding them exchanged a few words. Then, they were let inside.

Once the Professor stepped into the room, he felt smothered in immediate tension. He took stock - at key points throughout the room were more of those black robed mages. Near the back, were a handful of scientists and engineers of the Deep Core project. At the center of the room, was Marka.

Not only Marka, but Solomon Richter, standing around a magical projection of the Deep Core schematics.

The two of them turned. Marka grimaced, but Solomon had an expecting smile.

"Professor [*****]," Solomon's voice echoed like black static in the Professor's ears. "And the protege himself, Jude Kirisame. I've hard many good things about you, young man."

The Professor stood in between two.

"No pleasantries, Solomon," the Professor said. "You put in a lot of effort to get him here. Now I get to find out why."

"Then let's get straight in to it," Solomon took a step back from the schematics and gestured to Marka. "Marka, if you would explain to the Professor some of the difficulties your team has been having."

Marka looked between the Professor and

the young boy behind him, then at Solomon.

She never had a good poker face, the conflict plain to see.

"Now, Miss Marka," the head of House Richter commanded.

Marika glanced at the Professor one last time and mouthed something of an apology before taking control of the schematics.

"Though our experiments and hypotheses, one of the key issues with creating a replacement for the Deep Core is our choice of material," Marka began.

"Contemporary materials such as gems and metals are too inflexible for our purpose, while enchanted materials such as manasteel is too expensive and will take too long to enchant."

"To remedy this, it has been proposed to go away from nonliving materials and explore living materials. One avenue we've chosen to pursue are bodies. A living body can conduct and store an incredible amount of magic. Our hypothesis is that a cadaver can do the same."

"Unfortunately, whatever process is driving that conductivity is halted whenever body is left. Call it soul, memory, or whichever mechanism it is, but the fact remains is that body alone is not enough."

The Professor frowned and felt his hand ache. He gripped Jude's hands tighter.

"Thank you very much, Miss Marka," Solomon stepped forward. "I've put a lot of thought into what you said, Professor. 'We have to do this the right way.' I agreed with you then, I agree with you

now. So I've really thought about what we can do to figure out what this 'right way' is."

"Then my contacts found out some interesting information," Solomon glanced behind the Professor.

"Out of the question," the Professor said immediately.

"I thought you'd say that," Solomon sighed and paced the room. His footsteps were deafening in the otherwise silent room. "Have you ever thought about it? How we get all those cadavers for the team to use?" He leveled a steely gaze at the Professor. "They weren't all from the Fissures, I'll tell you that much."

"We're all falling into shades of black, Professor," Solomon continued. "In my eyes, one person for the entirety of Ashen is a lighter shade."

Jude gripped onto the Professor with both hands.

"Absolutely not," the Professor said no again. "The dead is one thing, but the living is another."

"That's the thing, [*****]."

Professor winced at the static.

"How long will must we rely on the dead?" the head of House Richter's voice turned deep, filled with a deep and commanding bass. "No. Unless you are able to provide me with a satisfactory alternative, I will be taking matters into my own hands."

"And you agree with this?" the Professor looked at Marka, steel in his gaze and his voice.

Marka looked away and the Professor

understood. It didn't matter if Marka agreed or not. This was a roadblock and one that could be removed instantly. The Professor looked behind her at the engineers and scientists that were held in the back of the room.

If Marka was under fire, that would probably be something she could stomach. The Professor knew her well enough to know that. But if it wasn't her under fire, if it was someone who she was responsible for... Well, the Professor saw her make that choice once. No doubt, she'd do it again in a heartbeat.

The room suddenly seemed very small. Then he heard it. A gust of wind followed by laughter.

"The Archmages wouldn't stand for this," the Professor said. "I bet they don't even know."

"The Archmages are not here, nor do I answer to them," Solomon growled. "They answer to us."

"They don't see it that way," the Professor needed to buy time.

"Enough, Professor [*****]?" Solomon forced the issue. "The choice is yours."

"A choice? This is what you call it?" the Professor looked around, the black robed mages preparing a spell. Same problem as before, even if he had the first strike he'd immobilize one mage and the others will cook him alive. Would the ice be enough? No, Marka and the others would get caught it in.

"There's always a choice," the head of House Richter summoned a wand. "And it would appear that you chose poorly."

The Professor looked at Marka, who wouldn't meet his gaze. A thought popped into his head. Where was Seer?

"Depends on your allies," the Professor grabbed onto Jude. "*Seer! Emergency!*"

He shouted with his voice and with his mind. It was a small hope, one that he didn't dare make.

"Engage!" Solomon commanded. Spells formed and fired and the Professor shielded Jude with his body. There were too many, lights nearly blinding him. The Professor lamented his failure and waited for pain and death.

The Professor waited for the darkness. When it came, he didn't feel any pain. Jude shifted in place, but was otherwise breathing. The Professor opened his eyes and he was in a different room. It was his office, actually. Sitting on the bench, his hands shaped into a spell, was the Seer.

He breathed out and rubbed his temple.

"How long were you listening," the Professor asked him as he dusted Jude off and got to his feet.

"It's less listening and more interrupted," the Seer explained. "My talent is such that I can listen to everything and everyone, willingly or unwillingly. When you shouted, how could I not hear?"

The Seer made a couple more signs with his hands and then casted another spell. Glyphs appeared all over the walls and the windows darkened.

"There, now we are protected from your pursuers," the Seer said. "Now, can you enlighten me as to what this emergency of yours is?"

"One that I couldn't get out without magical assistance," the Professor said. "The High Houses are getting impatient."

"Marka hasn't notified me of anything," the Seer said. He furrowed his brow and tilted his head. "Though she seemed more stressed than usual. A solution to the conductivity problem?"

The Professor nodded, then turned to Jude.

"The Young Kirisame?" the Seer asked. "Why would he..." He trailed off and then

closed his eyes. He opened them again, his platinum eyes glowing with magic. "I understand."

The Professor suddenly broke out into a cold sweat. What if Seer agreed with them?

The Seer nodded and then closed his eyes again. When they opened, they were normal.

"It would be a quick solution," Seer said. "Especially if we forgo everything and keep the Young Kirisame alive. It would be a type of hell for you, Young Kirisame, but it's feasible."

Jude took a step back, eyes wide.

"Personally, I'm against it," the Seer added. "Lest you forget, I did push for the first delay."

The Professor couldn't help but sigh in relief and sat on the ground.

"Do not rest too soon, Professor," the Seer said. "Your troubles are many and your allies few."

That's when the Professor noticed for the first time - the Seer seemed to sit up straighter, his chest out. There was an air of confidence around him that wasn't there when the Professor first met him.

He had the aura of someone who knew all the answers.

"What do you know?" the Professor asked.

"A great deal," the Seer said.

"Are you at liberty to share?"

The Seer shrugged. "Some things, yes, other things no. It's a little difficult to sort out which is which."

"New job?" the Professor's thoughts

began to fire.

"New role," the Seer nodded. "Though I suggest we step off this topic quickly."

"And why is that?"

The room shook.

"Because despite the ward and new role, this is not my specialty," the Seer explained. "And while my skill is high, quantity can overcome quality."

"Then tell me what I need to know," the Professor got to his feet.

"First, after I give you this information, I will not be able to provide you further help," the Seer said. "One of the stipulations to my new role was to become more impartial in Ashen. At least for a year."

The Professor furrowed his brow as he tried to decipher this puzzle. But regardless, he nodded.

"Second, think back to your recent encounter," the Seer said. "Were they acting strange? Not necessarily out of character, but more heightened."

The Professor thought for a moment. "Marka seemed the same, but I've seen Solomon act this way before. When the pressure is at it's highest and it's life or death."

"Is this a situation that calls for that?"

"No," the Professor shook his head. "Even with the delays, we are years away from forcing the issue. I understand someone less experienced being more or less impatient, but Solomon's been doing this as long as I have."

The Professor paced his office. "He's more level-headed than this. Which means he's being influenced."

"As are you," the Seer said.

"The laughter."

"The what?"

"Ever since taking down Allen, I've been hearing laughter," the Professor explained. Then he remembered. "Speaking of, you didn't throw me in that dream a couple weeks back, did you?"

"Why would I wake you from a dream I supposedly threw you in?" the Seer countered.

"Lord and Lady Vei seemed to think so," the Professor shrugged.

"The High Houses have a poor impression of my family, perhaps House Vei the most," the Seer said. "Within good reason, of course."

"Still," the Professor continued pacing. "The laughter follows me. Follows me like the wind."

"Hm," the Seer thought for a moment. "Yes, that would make sense."

"What would?" the Professor looked at him.

"When you asked me to find someone for you, I found duplicate signals," the Seer explained. "Several duplicate signals. The one by the Vei Chateau was the strongest of it."

"You already know the true source of the signals," the Professor surmised.

"Then that would mean-" the Seer looked up, surprised. "Yes, I do know. How did you jump to that?"

"Because I've been that mage enough times to know when someone already has the answer," the Professor said.

"It's addicting, isn't it? Another reason I took the role," the Seer confessed.

The room shook again.

"A location," the Professor said. "I don't even need a name."

"I can give you both," the Seer looked at Jude. "But once I do, it will conclude the help I can give you. So let me ask one final question. What will you do with the young Kirisame?"

Jude had lost interest in the conversation and was exploring the warding glyphs on the walls, tracing them with his finger. At hearing his name, he jumped at attention and turned back to the two adults.

"Despite my reservations, Solomon is correct in way," the Seer said. "The boy can serve Ashen well."

"He's not an experiment," the Professor said.

"Don't misunderstand me," the Seer held a hand up. "I mean him all the best. But you will not be able to protect him forever."

"No, not forever," the Professor agreed. "But long enough."

The Seer nodded.

"The location is on the rim of Mount Alchaic, to the west of the caldera. The name is Dena."

The Professor stopped. "Dena Black. My second protege."

"With that, we have reached the end of my assistance," the Seer said. "I wish I could give you more."

"You've given me enough," the Professor held his hand out to the Seer for a handshake. "Thank you, Master Seer."

"For your assistance in getting me here, it is the least I can do," the Seer shook his hand.

After shaking, the glyphs disappeared and Seer with them. The door burst open and two mages pushed through, spells ablazing.

"Jude, Ice!" the Professor jumped to the side. The Professor's voice a whip.

The room dropped several degrees, jagged spikes of ice thrown into the entranceway. Jude stood at the desk, frost forming on his robes.

The Professor returned to his feet and tugged on Jude's arm.

"It'll be too dangerous on your own, but if you do end up separate from me, as much ice as you can everywhere, understood?" the Professor instructed. "I'll come find you."

Jude nodded.

The Professor rolled up his sleeves and wrung his wrist. "It's time for you to meet your senior."

"We're at a severe disadvantage if we let them come to us," the Professor explained. "My advantage, and now ours, is that we strike first and strike fast. Block those corridors."

The Professor waltzed down the Chandlery and pointed at certain hallways. Jude did as commanded and for each one blocked there was a flurry of spellwork against it.

"Your ice is strong, that's good," the Professor said. "It'll buy us precious time."

The Professor lead the two of them through the Chandlery at a measured pace, not running, but with the cocksure confidence of someone who practically owned the building. The two of them looped around in circles and circles, up to the point where they were behind some mages.

The Professor struck first and fast, felling mages as they came.

"Mages are strong," the Professor said. "But if you catch them unaware, they'll fall like all the rest."

Like this, the two of them made it to the bottom of the Chandlery. The Professor waited for a moment at the bottom of a set of stairs and then gestured for Jude to wait too.

"If I were a competent battle commander, I would've surrounded the bottom of the Chandlery," the Professor said.

Jude nodded.

The Professor took a step out of the stairs and a tension appeared, like moments before a lightning strike. He

stepped back into the staircase and magic blasted the bottom of the Chandlery.

"And they are, in fact, competent," the Professor said. "That makes things difficult."

The Professor thought for a spell. Then he turned right around and went back up the stairs.

"Here we go, Jude," the Professor said. "There's back doors, but Solomon would know them too. Do you know how to remote start?"

Jude shook his head.

"Remote starts are difficult for talents," the Professor said. "But I'll teach you."

He lead them to one of the back entrances which go underground.

"Imagine a tether from yourself to the ice seed here," the Professor said. "Keep that tether to you, thin as you can, and stick close. We'll have other exits to time."

Jude nodded and did what he was told. Professor counted several exits, seven in total. At the seventh, Jude was breathing heavily, the boy shivering.

"There's more, but this'll do," the Professor led Jude back to the bottom of the Chandlery. "Whenever you're ready, send ice through the tethers and expand. An explosive expansion, to make some noise."

Jude nodded and closed his eyes. The temperature dropped further and ice formed around him. Like a fuse lit, bluish light traveled down the tethers.

The Professor counted to himself.

At ten seconds, one of the tethers on Jude snapped. From faraway, the Chandlery shook. Another two seconds later, a couple more tethers snapped followed by the same number of rumblings.

"With me, keep focusing," the Professor took Jude by the hand and led him through the Chandlery's main entrance. The last of the tethers broke and Jude released an icy breath.

The two of them made it through the front entrance. A handful of mages still watched the entrance, but they were distracted by the other explosions and communications to their superiors.

"Quickly, the two on the left!" the Professor ran to the right.

Ice burst from Jude, engulfing the two mages the Professor pointed out.

Three were still active and trained spells on the boy, but the Professor were upon them like a raging bear. Two, three strikes, and the first two were down. But the third had some time to prepare themselves.

They saw the Professor's punch coming and pulled out a glyph, the Professor's punch hitting solid air. With their other hand, the drew a dagger from within the robes. They mouthed words and the dagger glowed a deep red, duplicates forming in the air.

The magic daggers angled towards the Professor, who gave it a beat, then rolled out of the way. The daggers pierced the air where he was, catching the edges of his robe. The mage followed with the dagger in his hand - the Professor used

that as his opportunity.

The dagger pierced his robes, but the Professor angled his body away and used the cloth to trap the mage's hand. The Professor pulled them close, headbutted them, then kneed them in the chest, twisting the dagger out of their hand, sending the weapon clattering to the floor.

The magic daggers faded and the Professor didn't let up. As fast as the mage could throw up shields, the Professor was faster. Or rather, the Professor was more efficient, already moving to the next move while the mage was reeling from the previous.

After a flurry of strikes, that mage joined the rest.

Jude ran up to the Professor, who took a moment to catch his breath.

"Good," the Professor dusted some frost off of Jude's robes. "We have precious seconds before they realize your ice was a distraction."

Jude nodded and took a step with the Professor, but something stopped him.

An alarm in the Professor's head went off and he slammed his foot on the spot where the mage fell - his foot just hit the ground.

Rolling to the side and revealing themselves after casting a shade for the briefest of moment. They gripped onto Jude's ankle and already completed a spell.

"No!" the Professor dove to join the spell, but the two of them blinked in a twinkle of light. "Ashes take me," the

Professor swore. He should have confirmed the knock-out before taking a breath.

The Professor looked around - a mage of that caliber shouldn't have gotten far with a quick teleport like that.

There was a rumble to the far north, way past the Chandlery. The Professor took a step towards it, then stopped.

Paths and possibilities ran through his head. The rumbling was Jude, he was sure of it. If the Professor knew that, then so would the others.

How fast can he get there? How fast can he catch up to them if they get to Jude? Even if he was there, could the Professor extradite Jude against several black-robed mages. Even against five, he needed Jude to distract some and the element of surprise to dispatch the others.

If he had magic, he'd be able to do it. Even an enchantment will do.

The Professor looked towards Mount Alchaic. Dena Black, the orchestrator, was waiting there. A previous protege of his. Talent. Intelligence. Delusion.

Possibly the Professor's greatest mistake. His Folly. His hand ached as he remembered that day five years ago, where his Folly came back to haunt him.

This time, he'd make it right.

He pointed his gaze to the rumble one more time. A cold wind blew through him. There was no laughter.

"Hang in there," the Professor said to the wind. Then he ran into the city and flagged a ferryman to take him closer to Mount Alchaic.

At the Professor's insistence, the Ferryman took no further passengers and beelined towards Mount Alchaic.

"Losing a lot of stral for this," the Ferryman said. "Don't suppose you could tell me why I'm risking my next meal for this."

"An Ashen Emergency," the Professor said.

"The usual then," the Ferryman rolled their eyes. One hand working the transport, the other flipping through a black book, he stopped at a page. The Ferryman squinted and looked between the page and the Professor, then asked, "The Esteemed Professor of the Chandlery?"

"Esteemed?"

"Traveler's guild has a list of persons of interest," the Ferryman held out the page and swerved their through Ashen streets. A picture of the Professor was there, with some form of information that the Professor didn't recognize. "This way, we know who to send the bill in case of an Ashen Emergency."

"Is that new?" the Professor had never heard of a system for the Ferries.

"Came into effect a couple moons or so," the Ferryman closed the book. "Sit down, we're about to hit the mountain roads. Ferry's not responsible for customer injuries."

The Professor stayed on his feet, but after a side-eye from the Ferryman, he thought better of it and sat.

The mountain words are easily traversable by foot - the same cannot be said to Ashen transports. Mount Alchaic

used to be a volcanic mountain, but ever since it erupted over two thousand years ago, it turned into a caldera. A portion of Ashen resides in that Caldera, enjoying the immense magic that pours out. That self-same magic wafts over the side of the mountain, making forms of magical transport turbulent and choppy.

It was all too true in this rickety ferry. The Professor jostled and was shoved all over the transport, while the Ferryman hummed a child's tune to himself.

Their way brightened and the Professor looked up to see a fireball flying in their direction.

The Ferryman swerved and kept his nostalgic tune. "Didn't see a report of eruption today."

"No eruption, but that's where I'm heading," the Professor saw more fireballs crest over the rim of Mount Alchaic. The sun was almost touching the horizon, giving the illusion of another fireball. The Ferryman dodged a couple other explosions. "Can you get me there?"

"Double the special rate," The Ferryman smoothly replied.

"Done," the Professor said. He didn't know what the special rate was, or how they got his billing address. He didn't even realize he had a billing address, but if he was willing, he was able.

"Done deal. Hold on tight," the Ferryman completed the deal and then muttered something under his breath. The transport warped and shuddered. Looking off to the side, the Professor saw it intake more of the ambient magic.

If not for the Ferryman's warning, the Professor would've been thrown off the back. The Ferryman navigated turbulent magic currents and incoming explosions with the practice and ease.

"Your stop's coming up, want a soft landing?" the Ferryman said.

The Professor almost said yes, but then thought better of it.

"Would it cost me extra?"

"Of course," the Ferryman said.

"Hard landing," the Professor said.

The Ferryman grunted in response. Perhaps it was in respect.

A minute or so of hard riding.

"Here we go," the Ferryman said. "When I say jump, you jump!"

"And the bill?"

The Ferryman tapped the black book. "I'll send it to your billing address."

The Professor nodded. Another two explosions.

"Now!" The Ferryman commanded.

The Professor jumped as the Ferryman swerved the transport. Like a rock in a slingshot, he was thrown over the edge of the caldera, soaring through the air.

Two fireballs passed by him, the heat scorching the ends of his robes. But once past that, he saw his target. A small compound adorned with glyphs and barriers.

The hard landing came, but the Professor rolled to a stop only a little worse for wear. The Professor dusted himself off and noted the Ferryman's professionalism. Dropped right outside his destination.

The sun was halfway set, long shadows casted down on Ashen. Within moments, the sun disappeared over the horizon.

The fireballs had stopped, the wards going down. The Professor walked forward and mulled over what it meant.

The fireballs were certainly Dena's work, as were the wards. Meant to ward away people that weren't the Professor. But now that the Professor was here, there was no point to the defenses.

As the Professor approached, the compound collapsed into itself, revealing a single person within.

The Professor realized it as he approached, the compound was never a compound. It was just a front for a ritual circle. The circle pulsed and glowed with soft, ethereal light. It was active.

He stopped right outside of it.

A woman in white, with skin as pale as a ghost, and eyes black as the night sky. As the Professor's eyes adjusted to the light, he found that the white wasn't robes or clothes. It was pure magic of all colors. Her body ebbed and flowed with the power of the circle and of that magic.

"Professor! How good of you to join me!" Dena spoke, but not words left her mouth. Instead, the words were beamed directly to the Professor's head. "Have you missed your prized pupil?"

"Of course I miss him, I miss him everyday," the Professor said. "I have you to thank for that."

"You can speak to him if you wish!" Dena spoke. Then like an image out a dream, a second head appeared on her body.

It shimmered and shook like a mirage, until a bald-faced man formed. The lips moved, but they made no sound. "He says he has no regrets."

"No doubt, that is what you hear," the Professor walked the perimeter of the magic circle. He studied it, no comfortable walking in until he knew what it does.

"It's an amplifier for my magic," Dena explained. The Professor must've held a poker face, for Dena made the motion of laughing. The wind followed it. "I thought you were in a rush? With the power of my spells, I can nudge anyone into the direction of my choosing."

"What direction would that be?"

"For the good of Ashen, of course!" Dena smiled a smile too wide and flourished the circle. "We make the hard decisions you can't and the city prospers!"

"At cost to everyone down below," the Professor said. The same song and dance.

"But here is where we differ," Dena said. "Have you forgotten the point of it all? The point of Ashen? You, the Archmages, and everyone else has! Selarune fell and Selarune was greater than us!" Dena began to float. "No! We will not fall to the same mistakes as before!"

"And the boy?" the Professor asked, his voice soft.

"Do you want to see the Young Jude Kirisame? Do you want to see the boy you left behind to come find me instead?" Dena asked. Magic swirled and a picture formed of the north outside of Ashen. A massive

pillar of ice towered over the land. Mages of all sorts blasted it with magic, trying to break into it. "How long do you think the boy can last?"

"Enough, Dena," the Professor looked back into the magic circle. He knew where to strike in order to dispel it. After that, he j6

"What's one to the needs of the many?" Dena floated down and stood face to face with the Professor. Then, aloud with her own voice, raspy and cold, she said, "That's what you taught me."

"To my shame and regret," the Professor said. "Have you said everything you needed to say?"

Dena smiled and shook her head. "Have you?"

"I doubt I ever will," the Professor took a step into the magic circle.

Like a snake, Dena struck. Magic pulsed from the circle and erupted from Dena, a pure tide of magic.

The Professor dashed to the side and ran around the circle.

"Not going to try to get in my head again?" The Professor shouted over the roaring tide.

"I've been trying all day!" Dena laughed. "But your mind is steel."

"Then for both our sakes, release yourself from you delusion!"

Dena laughed again.

"We're all deluded here, Professor!" Dena's voice was shrill. "You, most of all!"

Magic welled from below him. The

Professor kept running. Torrent after torrent flew and the Professor only just dodged it. Magic caught on his robes, setting it alight.

When the Professor was a younger man, he reasoned that encounters were a series of questions and answers. Does he have an answer to the torrent of magic coming towards him? Even if he survives a second longer, can he get to Dena and deal a deathblow before she responds with a deathblow of her own?

The Professor stumbled and rolled through another torrent of magic. This wasn't a spell that he could exploit a weak point in. This was raw magic wrought with force of will.

Then as magic exploded in front of him, a thought came to him. A scary thought, a question asked of him some time ago.

Can I do magic without spells?

It was delusional to entertain the thought. Several years of losing his magical talent. Rules which prevented chaos.

But he was running out of answers.

The Professor threw his hands forward and collected his will in front of him. With iron intent, he grabbed the magic.

The magic obeyed and the torrent that chased him ceased. He made a breather and as the magic ebbed and nipped at the tattered edges of his robes.

Dena floated above him, her smile wide and knowing.

"And there he is!" She said. "The Prodigy of Ashen, the Next Archmage! Breaking his own rules! Just like us!"

The Professor held his hand out and willed magic to smite her out of the air. When nothing happened, Dena frowned. The Professor breathed out, a part of him relieved.

The Professor couldn't feel the magic around him. Not like he used to. He looked at the circle around him. That's magic right there. It'll be enough.

"You thought that if I was like you, I'd join your cause," the Professor surmised. "Unlike you and yours, I cannot bend reality to my whims. All I can do is influence what's in front of me. Meaning that for now, I'm just like everyone else."

Dena shrieked and there was an immediate mental pressure.

The Professor let it roll over him. Now that he knew what the attack was, his mind did its job as a steel wall. A second battle occurred as Dena flew down and attacked. Her hands summoned waves of sharp energy, striking at the Professor with reckless abandon.

She wasn't as skilled as the Professor was at hand to hand combat, not even close. It was a weakness the Professor often mentioned to her. It was now something that the Professor took full advantage of. Despite the lethality of her hands, the Professor targeted her arm. And whenever he caught a strike en-route, he exerted his will and pulled some magic away from her and struck back.

The Professor thought about the questions he was posing to Dena. Did she have an answer to his hand to hand combat?

What about magic? If the Professor could see it, he could react to it. Even mental magic was something that he anticipated and can react to.

Dena grew frustrated and summoned more magic. Like stars in the sky, a hundred magical orbs appeared. Then, some of the orbs disappeared. The circle below them pulsed and glowed.

The Professor grimaced. If it was something he couldn't see or feel with his tactile senses, the Professor wouldn't be able to react in time to convert the magic to his own. The second, brute force option also existed - simply overwhelm him before he could react. A two prong attack.

A cold wind blew through him. In his rush for battle, he had momentarily forgotten why he was here. He needed to break the spell.

The Professor refocused on the circle and in a split second, analyzed it for the weak point. Every spell had one. Every rune, every glyph, and every magic circle. He spotted several, but also found that each one had a feedback contingency; meaning that if he only took one out, the others would overcompensate and amplify the spell. A last gasp, as it were.

It would also kill him, but that was the lesser problem in his eyes.

His split-second ended.

"What will it be Professor!?" Dena shouted over the myriad orbs she summoned. "Your protege or your life?"

The weaknesses memorized, he looked up at Dena, who was already pointing at the Professor, orbs turning into blasts.

He looked at her, at the construct which was once a protege of his own. A construct made of magic and a flawed soul.

The Professor breathed out and jumped towards her. He brushed through some magic orbs on the way, the magic not converted into harm just yet. That was the benefit of acting first - catching the unprepared made life a little easier.

He caught that magic and used it to aid his journey, before colliding into Dena. In one smooth move, he turned his will into a scalpel and punched through her chest. The magic parted for him and he grabbed the orb of light that he knew was there. Similar to Allen, Dena would have one. How else would she keep her soul intact?

"No!"

"The future has no place for ghosts," the Professor said. Then he squeezed. The orb cracked under his will. Then it shattered, the light inside scattering to the night sky.

The magic in her construct shattered as well, but before it could completely, the Professor collected it for his own purposes. He found the weaknesses, then in one strike, he used the magic to pierce the magic circle in an instant. The Professor dropped to the ground as the circle flared. A pulse ran through all of Ashen, like a breath escaping.

Then, the magic in the circle scattered into the night sky as well.

The Professor looked around, trying to catch anything he missed. When he was met with stillness, the Professor collapsed.

The adrenaline faded from his system and his everything hurt and ached.

There was a price for using magic without the proper senses. He didn't know what it was completely, but after a night's rest, he had no doubt that he'll find out.

After a moment, he shot to his feet and started running down the mountain. He needed to find a ferryman and get to the Northern outskirts.

He needed to find the young Kirisame.

Half running and half limping, the Professor did manage to flag a Ferryman down. It wasn't the same Ferryman as before, but when the Professor told him his destination, the Ferryman grunted and took him there with no fuss.

Despite the wave rolling through Ashen, the citizens weren't too worried. Some poked their heads out of their windows and looked around, while others were discussing with their fellows.

Most of them went about their day when no follow-up came. The only person who knew what occurred was the Professor. The Ferryman didn't ask about his tattered robes or his myriad hurts. Just another day on the job for him, the Professor surmised.

The Ferry dropped the Professor off at the northern border. It was a busy checkpoint, the ethereal light of magic pulsing as a barrier was erected above the walls.

"Excuse me," the Professor pushed through the crowd around the checkpoint. There was always a crowd of people coming in and out. The first couple tried to push back, but a tired glare from the Professor quieted them.

It was something in his eyes or his presence, where the Professor could repel the rabble. A handy trick, especially when he needed to make sure anyone who wasn't in the know can stay out of the know.

He got to the checkpoint and the guard there took one look at the Professor before wordlessly letting him through.

The Professor mused to himself that the

guard should have been more diligent. But he supposed that because he was leaving, it didn't matter to Ashen if he was gone or not.

The Professor limped outside of Ashen and found what he was looking for. A massive pillar of ice was further ahead, small crowd surrounding it. As the Professor approached, he saw that most of the crowd was a perimeter of guards, keeping others away. Closer to the pillar were the black robed mages from before. A lot of them sat, holding their heads and shaking them like they were in a trance.

Among them was Solomon Richter, who stood there with his hands on his hips, facing the pillar.

The Professor limped through the guards and stood next to Richter.

"Professor," Richter greeted. "You look like you've fought your worst nightmare."

"You look like you've woken up from one," the Professor retorted.

Richter grunted. "Despite it all, I don't disagree with it."

"Is that right?" the Professor scowled.

"Not completely anyway," Richter said. "You're right, of course. We need other options in order to be better than the monsters."

"Then why?"

"Because we need to be ready when we don't have any other option," Richter said. "I don't like it any more than you do. But I'll be dead and buried before I let my personal feelings cause Ashen."

"Ashen? Or your house?"

"There isn't a difference," Richter replied. He sighed and snapped his fingers. The black-robed mages stood at attention. Even the ones who were dazed got to their feet, though they swayed. "Dismissed."

With one word, the abled mages grabbed their fellows and teleported away.

"Enjoy your retirement, Professor. Take care of yourself," Richter said. "The boy as well."

The Professor watched Richter leave, right until the head of House Solomon warped his own way out a handful of steps away.

The Professor limped towards the pillar of ice.

"You did well, Jude," the Professor said. "The danger is over."

The ice started to defrost. It was slow goings, slow enough for the Professor to wonder if it would take all night. Then the Professor blinked and he was no longer on the outskirts of Ashen.

Instead he was someplace dark, smelling of sulfur. Soft, volcanic light illuminated the darkness he was in, giving everything a red hue.

The pillar of was with him, shrunken until it was no larger than a scale model, large enough to be picked up and carried leisurely. It was saturated with gray, as if it was locked in stasis.

One by one, spotlights with no physical origin illuminated a stone chair in a circle around the Professor, until thirteen chairs surrounded him.

The next moment, nine of the thirteen

chairs were filled.

One chair was higher than the others, the chair of the Head Archmagus.

A single moment of silence, then the white-robed man who sat at that chair stood and raised their arms.

"Archmages, please rise and confirm your attendance," The Archmagus said.

Starting from the Archmagus' left, power began to thrum as Archmages spoke.

"Archmage of Elements, present."

"Archmage of Crafts, present."

"Archmage of Souls, present."

"Archmage of Seas, present."

A pause and an empty chair.

"Archmage of Industry, present."

"Archmage of Coin," a middle-aged, fat man remained seated. "Here."

Another pause and another empty chair.

"Archmage of Arcana, present."

Two more pauses. Two more empty chairs.

"I am here," an ancient man to the right of the Archmagus weakly said.

"Archmage of Relics."

"Archmage of Barriers and Archmagus of Ashen," the Archmagus looked at the empty chairs, then at the Professor. "Present."

The Professor forced himself to relax. He couldn't show weakness or fear. Not now, not at this critical junction. The very fact that the Professor was here and not thrown to the wayside told him that they needed something from him.

"It is the will of the Archmages of Ashen to proceed upon two cases," His voice boomed throughout the room, filling it with power and tension. "The first, is

the ascension of a new Archmage."

The Professor frowned. He clearly wasn't the candidate. Then who?

"Elatha Essaim, please approach."

A spotlight appeared next to him, in which the Master Seer appeared from a portal. His platinum eyes glowed with power and though the Seer was a tad smaller than the Professor and more than half his age, he stood with a dignified pride.

"Professor," the Seer greeted him with a small bow.

"So this is your new role?" the Professor wasn't too terribly surprised.

"I've been promised new clothes," the Seer said. He turned to the Archmages. "Master Seer, Elatha Essaim, present."

"Master Seer, for your skills in magic and sight, as well as your contributions in surveillance, the Archmages of Ashen grant you the status of Archmage. Do you accept?"

"I do," Seer bowed in acceptance.

"Then come, take your place as Archmage of Sight," the Archmagus gestured to an empty chair. The Seer, now Archmage took a deep breath and then warped to the chair, now wearing the white robes of an Archmage.

The room was silent, with no further fanfare.

"The second case is the of Ashen's rising energy crisis," the Archmagus said. "Archmage of Coin, Archmage of Industry, what say you?"

"Slow as ever," the fat, Archmage of

Coin said. He lounged in his chair and produced a goblet from his robes. "I'm sure the Archmage of Industry can explain it better than I."

"Though we have the best and brightest mages working on it, the best they can come up with are flashes in a pan," the Archmage of Industry explained. "We have several projects, from the Deep Core, Heavenly Wards, even Shore Sailors. None of them can sufficiently meet our projected needs in the near future, let alone the far future. Replacing our current core would be impossible at this rate."

"Is that right?" the Archmagus looked at the Professor, as did all the other Archmages. "Esteemed Professor [*****], I hear you were retired. Ashen thanks you for your contribution to the Deep Core even post-retirement and we offer you our thanks."

"Archmagus," the Professor nodded. "I'm sure we're all busy. What do you need from me?"

"Straight to the point, as always," the Archmagus' voice had a twinge of amusement. "As one of our brightest, what is your opinion?"

"My opinion is that I'm likely to get killed speaking it," the Professor said.

"Certainly hasn't stopped you before," the Archmage of Elements quipped.

The Professor pointed at them and was about to respond, but held his tongue and returned his hand.

"My professional opinion is that there are several shortcuts to solve this

problem that a variety of my colleagues are looking to employ. While effective, it is shortsighted and prone to causing the self-same issues which has lead to many a problem."

"That's your opinion on a problem," the Archmagus said. "What of your opinion on the solutions?"

"To put it blunt, there are none," the Professor replied. "It would require a miraculous breakthrough on par with the creation of the circle."

"A miracle almost three thousand years old," the Archmage of Arcana said.

"And miracles are precisely what Ashen specializes in," the Archmagus said.

"Archmage of Sight. You were also monitoring the project. What say you?"

"The Professor is right," the Seer said. "The shortcuts are too dangerous. For the Deep Core in particular, the original core was created with materials and processes that are unrepeatable. Once in an eternity type of processes."

"And alternatives?"

"One," the Archmage of Sight said.

The Professor glared at him.

"The Young Kirisame has the potential to be as aetherial conductive as the current material we use."

A thoughtful hush went over the room. The Archmagus of Coin swirled his goblet and looked between the Professor and the boy in stasis.

"He's a citizen of Ashen, as brokered with Samidare," the Professor said. "The Oath was writ with blood and soul."

The Archmage of Souls scoffed. "Whether citizen or oath, that hasn't stopped the city from doing what needs to be done."

"You would break your Oath with Samidare?" the Professor challenged.

A new tension appeared in the room. A few Archmages shuffled in their seats.

The Archmagus did not. "If it would result in Ashen surviving, then yes. Can you offer us an alternative?"

The Professor could not.

"Then under joint oversight of the Archmage of Sight, Archmage of Coin, and Archmage of Industry, we are to move forward with the Deep Core," The Archmagus decreed. "That will be all. Dismissed."

Then in the next moment, the Professor was returned to outside of Ashen, where he was prior. The young Kirisame was in front of him, removed from his icy pillar, though unconscious.

Master Seer, now the Archmage of Sight, accompanied them.

"I thought you said you were against it," the Professor glared.

"I did," the Archmage said. "I still am."

"And yet you pushed for this?"

"Bereft of an alternative, yes."

"We both know there is none!" the Professor shouted. He took a deep breath and calmed down. "It's been a long day. There isn't a quick one."

"I'm sorry to say, that isn't good enough," the Archmage of Sight sighed.

The Professor gave him a severe, if weary, stare. Then he also sighed and went

to pick Jude up.

"I'll be coming for him in some time," the Archmage of Sight said. "The priorities of Ashen must take precedence."

The Professor thought about giving him a retort. Instead, he kept moving back into the city and took the young Kirisame somewhere safe. Back to the Chandlery.

The Professor was tired. Tired of running around, tired of the politics, tired of pushing himself to his limit day after day.

In this exhaustion, was the exact moment that his superiors within the Chandlery decided to have his first ever teaching review. An actual one, with some measure of warning.

And so, while he was in the middle of a lecture, the Professor saw three hooded individuals in black robes enter the lecture hall and observed.

The Professor didn't let his annoyance show in his lecture. He continued on with magical theory and then dismissed them to let another Professor walk them through practical applications in the practice room. As the wicks filtered out of the lecture hall, the three observers didn't make a move.

The Professor cleaned the board and fielded questions as necessary. The last wick to leave was the young Kirisame, who waited for the Professor.

"Run along, Jude," the Professor said. "Tell Professor Marrow that I'll proctor your exam shortly."

If the boy was disappointed, he didn't show it. Briskly, with the same stoicism the Professor might have had, he left the lecture hall.

There was a long silence.

The Professor started to leave, when one of them stopped him with a magical field on the door.

"Well?" the Professor addressed them for the first time. "Get on with it then."

I haven't got all day."

The three of them turned to the Professor and kept their silence for a moment longer, then removed their hoods. The triumvirate of the Chandlery. The three Waxers.

"You've been very active recently," the one on the left of the room, closest to the door spoke first. Their voice was deep like rocks crashing against each other.

"Perhaps too active," the one of the far right spoke next. Their voice was smooth and light, like a forest stream. "And not for the right reasons."

"Our patience is thin," the one in the middle spoke. They were assertive and quick, like lightning. "We have given you plenty of grace, but at repeated intervals you violated the bounds of the agreement."

"Take it up with the High Houses," the Professor scoffed.

"That is not the agreement we are referring to," Rocks said.

"Indeed," Forest Stream nodded with their words. "We are aware of your efforts with the High Houses and with your continued work on the Deep Core. We regret that you must do so in your retirement, but we will not stop you."

"No concessions for Jude Kirisame," Lightning said. "That is what you promised."

"And that is what I have given," the Professor refuted. "In exchange for early admission, he is to work his through the years as a wick. No special handouts, exceptions."

"And yet he is your protege," Lightning

said.

"I'd hardly call that a handout or exception," the Professor said.

"For twenty years, wicks have sought that privilege. Barely a handful you've taken. In the last five, you've turned away all of them," Rocks said. "Is this not an exception?"

"If the other wicks were more talented and headstrong, I'd have more," the Professor said.

"Like Litwick Yewl?" Rock asked. There was a trap in that question. The Professor didn't know yet, what the full nature of it was, but he felt it in his hand.

"Like Litwick Yewl. And as I recall, she revoked that," the Professor said. Time to spring it.

"Ah, but there's a key difference between Litwick Yewl and Jude Kirisame," Forest Stream said. "One is here naturally, while the other you've had to fight for."

"The boy is talented," the Professor said. "It would be a waste of his talents otherwise."

"Talented," Forest Stream repeated. "How lovely a word. We are all talented here."

"Talent is the minimum," Rock said. "But it will not take him far."

"We agreed to your request," Lightning started down the stairs. "Because, like you, we saw a star in Jude Kirisame. But there is a prerequisite here, outside of age. Can Jude Kirisame cast magic or not?"

"He's a talented cryomancer, probably the best in his generation," The Professor

said.

"That's not the question we asked," Lightning said.

There's the trap. A distinction without a difference. What they were asking for was if Jude could control the magical energy which Ashen takes for granted. A natural affinity to an element wasn't that.

"The leniency we provided you was under the assumption he could not because of his sickness," Lightning continued. "But it has been almost a year since then, far past his recovery."

"We have no use for wicks who can't light their own fire," Forest Stream added. "As far as we're concerned, for all of his talents, Jude Kirisame is naught more than an empty battery, not fit to be a wick."

The Professor thought about the last couple of weeks. He thought about his recent encounter with the Archmages. He thought of what Ashen needed.

He clapped once. The sudden, sharp sound shocked the three Waxers. Lightning stopped in place, while the others jumped where they stood.

"Are we done with this farce?" the Professor asked. His voice was soft, yet stern. "You have made your decision and I have made mine."

Lightning reached the bottom of the lecture hall and stood opposite of the Professor.

"Effective immediately, Jude Kirisame is—"

The Professor punched them in the

throat before they could finish. He followed with a kick to right above their knee and the Waxer went down.

He looked up at the other two, who had spells at the ready. They haven't fired yet.

"Well?" The Professor raised his hand in the air, daring them to shoot. He moved away from the one on the ground. "Go on! I haven't got all day!"

The two of them hesitated.

"That's the problem with you feckless mages!" the Professor exclaimed. "Always ready to say a decision but never prepared to see it through!"

He continued walking, making it to the windows of the lecture hall. The Professor wondered if they thought he would jump out. For his own amusement, the Professor looked outside - this lecture hall were several stories above, with errant rooms flying about.

Still no magic attacked him.

"If that's how it's going to be, then I have a declaration of my own," the Professor turned back to them. "As witnessed by the thirteen Archmages of Ashen, and by Oath I swore to Samidare, I hereby declare Jude Kirisame as my protege."

"You wouldn't!" Forest Stream willed their spell into fruition, but a clap of thunder outside of the Chandlery stopped them in their tracks.

"I can," the Professor took the thunder as their acceptance. "And I have. Now let me leave before I force my way out."

Sticking to their pride, the two of

them made no move to take their barrier down. Then they looked at the Waxer on the ground.

"Of course they're the one who put it up," the Professor rolled his eyes and approached the barrier. He pushed against the magic, feeling something solid, yet spongy. His fingers traced up and down until his instincts found something imperceptible to anything but intuition. The Professor tore at the barrier, taking it down and strode out of the room.

That was what the Archmagus of Sight meant. If they needed an alternative, then that is what the Professor needed to give them. He needed to be that alternative.

By fire and faith, there was work to be done.